

DEEP DIVE ►► 5



ORGANISERS, SUPPORTERS DISPERSE PEACEFULLY

Agitation Ends, Fight for Justice On: Protesters

5-point reform charter submitted to Centre, will meet govt again in a month: CJP leaders

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: As the protest at Jantar Mantar led by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) drew to a close amid victory slogans on Saturday evening, organisers and supporters dispersed peacefully, vowing that this was not the end of their struggle and that they would continue to raise their voice on key issues in the coming days. Gen Z, millennials and others gathered at the site maintained that while the resignation of education minister Dharmendra Pradhan was welcome, there was a need for a systemic overhaul and greater accountability from the government.

The crowd cheered as the organisers announced that many had been asking what would become of the CJP now that its three demands had been met, asserting that "this is just the beginning". "We have presented a five-point exam reform charter to the government on how to make the exam system robust. We will meet the government again after a month on this issue... To make long story short, we have won," CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke announced from the stage.

CJP leaders also declared that the Centre had assured them that protesters in BJP-ruled states would not be harassed by the authorities.

Dipke also took a swipe at the Narendra Modi-led government du-

ring his brief address. "We had heard that no resignations happen in this government," he said, amid loud cheers. Protesters responded with chants of 'Bharat Mata ki Jai'. Many from Gen Z felt that there were already enough laws in place and that the priority should be to implement them in letter and spirit rather than continue enacting stricter legislation.

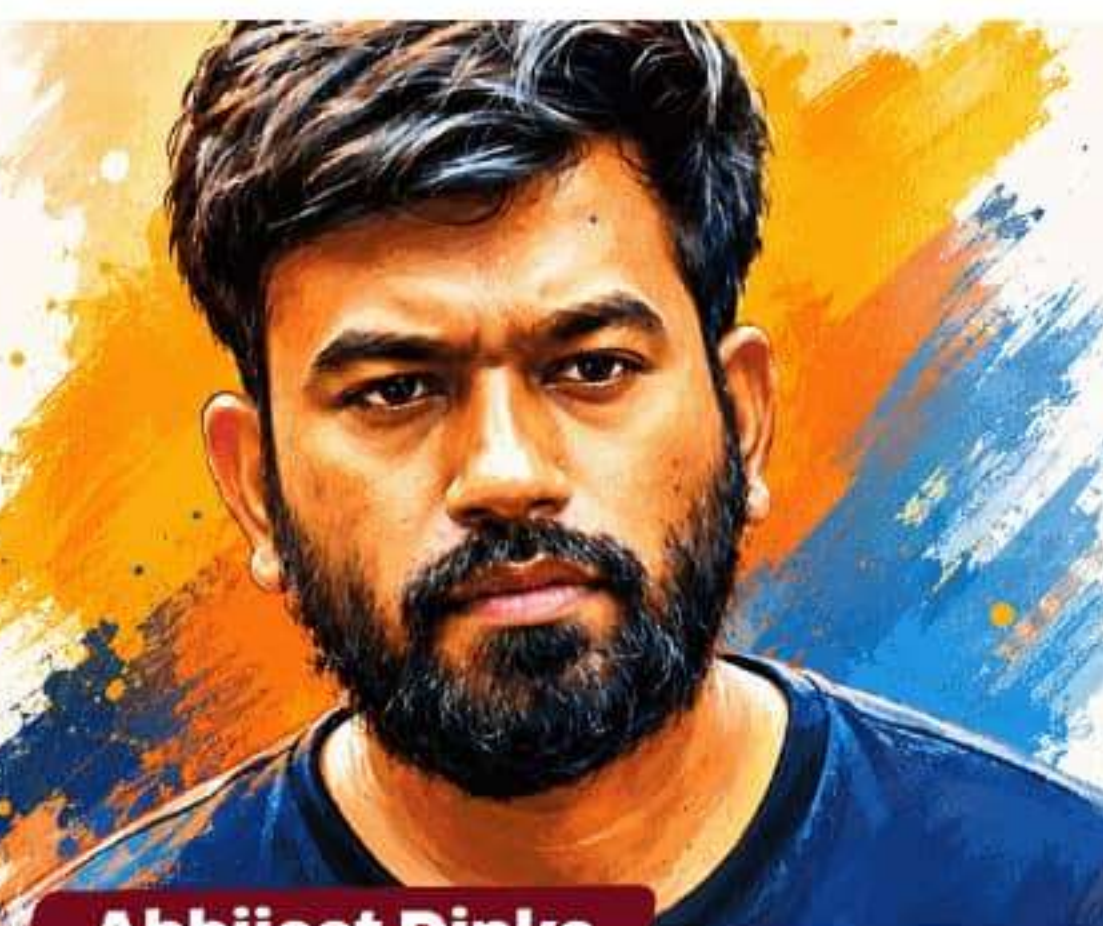
ET spoke to several people, from parents to millennials and Gen Z protesters, at the site soon after Pradhan announced his resignation. Some belonged to families directly affected by the NEET paper leak, while others had turned up in support of the cause.

Sara Firdous, a Class XII student preparing for next year's NEET exam, expressed satisfaction over the development. "Now I can prepare in peace and without the fear that the paper will be leaked. It was a trauma for those who had to suffer because of paper leaks," she said.

A few cited examples from other democracies where ministers and even PMs had resigned over comparatively smaller issues. "In the UK, we have seen seven PMs in the last decade. The last PM himself said he had not lived up to expectations and was stepping down," said Deepanshu, a software engineer. The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, which seeks to amend the 2024 law, is likely to provide for a minimum jail term of five years, extendable to 10 years, along with a fine of up to Rs 1 crore.



'Govt assured that the protesters in BJP-ruled states won't be harassed by the authorities'



Abhijeet Dipke
Founder & National Convenor of CJP
PR student at Boston University. Former social-media volunteer with AAP (2020-2023). Started the CJP X account on May 16, 2026, after CJI Surya Kant's remark. Came to India on June 6 and started a protest on June 20 against NEET paper leaks at Delhi's Jantar Mantar. The protest gained prominence after activist Sonam Wangchuk began a hunger strike at the protest site on 28 June, which he later ended on July 23.



Saurav Das
Chief Spokesperson, CJP
One of the prominent faces of CJP, Das has worked as an **investigative journalist who reported on legal, judicial and social issues.** He was also part of anti-pollution protests in Delhi in November 2025. Das holds a Bachelor of Arts in Journalism and Mass Communication from Amity University, where he studied between 2016 and 2019.



Ratna Singh
Spokesperson, CJP
A lawyer and a former legal journalist. Singh has been with the CJP from its initial days. Singh has emerged as one of the key public faces of the organisation, actively leading and coordinating its protests at Jantar Mantar.

FROM FARM LAWS TO STUDENT PROTESTS

Rollback to Reset: Modi Govt's Art of Political Recovery

Kumar Anshuman

New Delhi: The resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan has once again proved that the Modi government is willing to course-correct when the political fallout threatens to outweigh the gains and risks alienating key electoral constituencies. As student protests spread across the country particularly in BJP-ruled states, the government did not hesitate to hold talks with CJP to end the agitation and contain the political damage among its core support base.

Over 12 years in office, The Modi-led BJP has rolled back several decisions on previous occasions, only to return better prepared and stronger.

The first major example came in 2015, when the government proposed amendments to the Land Acquisition Act to ease norms for acquiring land for infrastructure projects. Facing stiff opposition from farmers, political parties and social activists, the government withdrew the amendments. In March 2018, the SC diluted certain provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. The changes triggered protests from the SC/ST community, NDA allies and then Union minister Ram Vilas Paswan. Sensing the potential political fallout, the government first brought an ordinance and later restored the original provisions through Parliament. The move, however, angered sections of the upper-caste community and BJP suffered defeats in the assembly elections in MP, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh in November 2018.

The government's next major retreat came over the three farm laws introduced in 2020. The legislation triggered widespread protests, with farmers from Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh camping at Delhi's borders for nearly a year. In November 2021, PM Narendra Modi announced the re-



FILE PHOTO

peal of the three farm laws, bringing the protests to an end. Senior BJP leaders then moved quickly to contain the political fallout, particularly in western Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand. The party retained power in both states, though it remained a marginal player in Punjab after parting ways with the Shiromani Akali Dal, winning just two seats.



Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation fits into BJP's broader pattern of political recalibration

In August 2024, the government announced lateral recruitment for Joint Secretaries and Directors. The proposal was opposed by NDA ally Chirag Paswan. The government rolled back the move without delay. Pradhan's resignation fits into this pattern of political recalibration. While such reversals are often portrayed as setbacks, BJP has shown that tactical rollbacks are not necessarily defeats. Instead, they have served as opportunities for the party to recalibrate its political strategy in response to changing public sentiment and electoral realities.

130 Cops, 65 Students Hurt; 15 FIRs over July 20 Protest: Police

Police identified 'anti-social elements' via facial recognition cameras

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: As many as 130 police personnel and around 65 students were injured during the July 20 "Sansad Chalo" protest march from Jantar Mantar towards Parliament, while 15 FIRs have been registered in connection with the demonstrations, officials said on Saturday.

"With the help of Facial recognition system cameras, Delhi Police is identifying anti-social elements at Jantar Mantar. Police have identified more than 2,000 such people so far who have criminal records and came to Jantar Mantar," police said. On July 20, the situation escalated as tens of thousands joined

the "Sansad Chalo" march, following which police erected barricades. Police responded with tear gas and lathi charges, leaving dozens on both sides injured. The crackdown triggered outrage across party lines and led to legal

CRIMINAL RECORDS



'Police identified over 2,000 people so far who have criminal records and came to Jantar Mantar'

petitions alleging excessive use of force. Police, however, blamed anti-social elements for stone-pelting and instigating violence.

CJP representative Ashutosh Ranka, meanwhile, claimed that the outfit would submit to Delhi Police a list of police personnel who allegedly "cracked open the heads of children, dragged them on the streets, broke the ribs of volunteers and slapped young girls."

Earlier, on July 21, FIRs were registered at Parliament Street and Connaught Place police stations under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, the Arms Act, 1959, and the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act (PDPP Act).

— (With agency inputs)

DHARMENDRA PRADHAN'S CABINET EXIT ENDS A TENURE, NOT HIS POLITICAL INFLUENCE

From ABVP to BJP's War Room: The Party Man Beyond the Ministry

Party continues to view him as one of the trusted leaders and election strategists

Jatin Takkar

New Delhi: Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation from the Union Cabinet may have ended his latest stint in government, but not necessarily his political relevance within the BJP.

While his tenure as education minister ended amid mounting pressure over examination-related controversies, party leaders continue to view him as one of BJP's most trusted organisational leaders and election strategists.

More an organisation man than a career minister, Pradhan began his political journey in ABVP,

during which he was injured in police action while protesting a paper leak in Odisha. He entered the Lok Sabha from Deogarh in 2004, when BJP was still a minor force in the state.

The son of former Union minister Debendra Pradhan, he emerged as one of BJP's principal faces in Odisha as the party expanded its footprint. An OBC leader from the Chasa community, he has frequently figured among the names discussed for the BJP president's post.

Within the organisation, Pradhan was entrusted with some of the party's most politically sensitive assignments, including Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. During turbulent phases in BJP-JDU ties, he

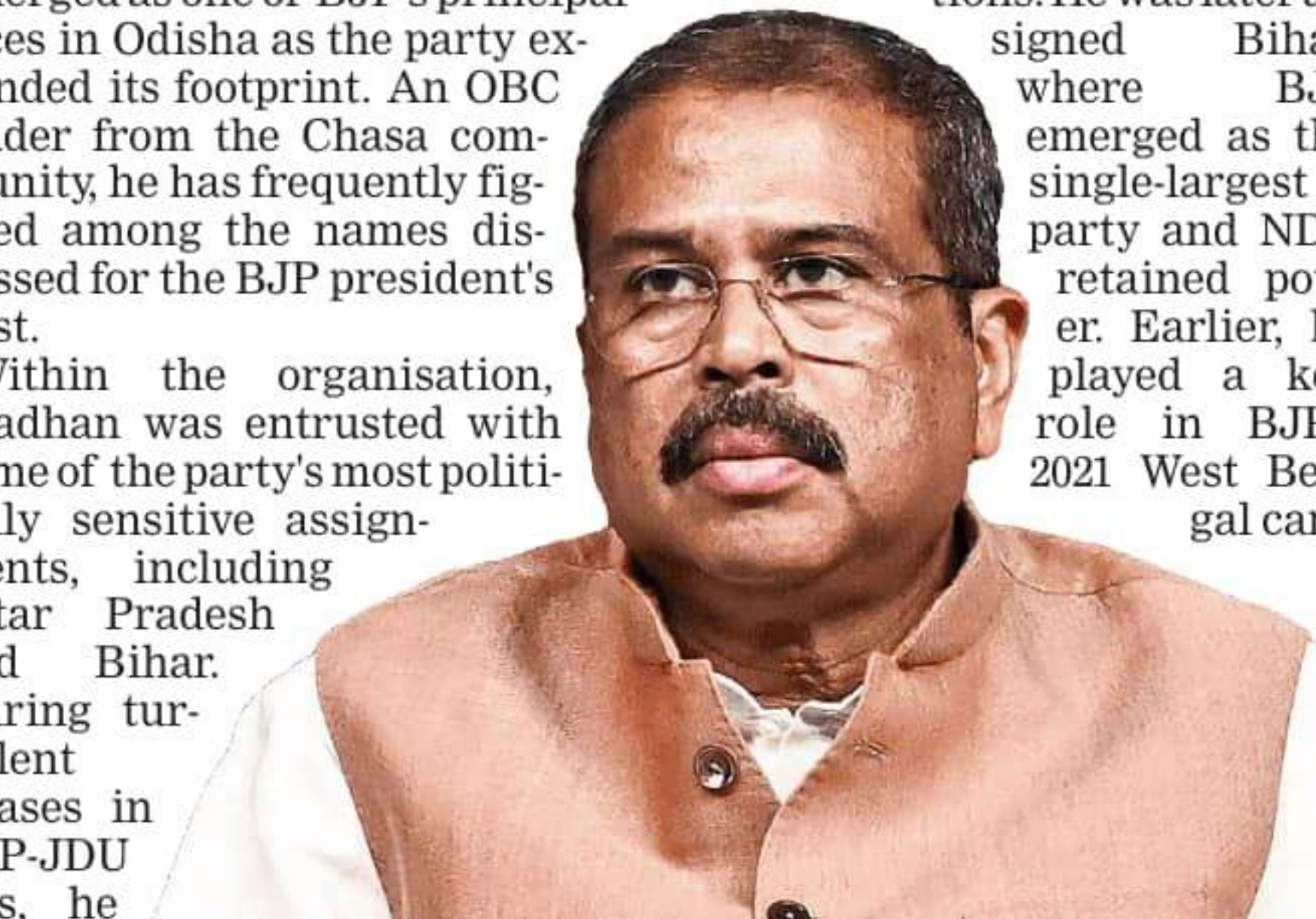
remained one of the party's principal channels of communication with Bihar CM Nitish Kumar.

His reputation as an election strategist grew after he steered the BJP to victory in Haryana despite anti-incumbency following the party's setback in 2024 elections. He was later assigned Bihar, where BJP emerged as the single-largest party and NDA retained power. Earlier, he played a key role in BJP's 2021 West Bengal cam-

paign, including the Nandigram contest in which Suwendu Adhikari defeated Mamata Banerjee, and was again among the party's key strategists in the 2026 assembly elections. He also played a central role in BJP's campaign that ended the BJD's 24-year rule in Odisha in 2024.

In government, however, his ministerial journey was more mixed. After heading the petroleum ministry for over seven years, his tenure in the education ministry came to be overshadowed by examination-related controversies, sustained Opposition attacks and questions over the functioning of the NTA, eventually leading to his resignation.

Within BJP, however, Pradhan's organisational record continues to outweigh his ministerial setback, ensuring that his resignation is viewed as the loss of a ministerial post rather than a diminution of his political relevance.



NEET, U-Turns Shadow Pradhan's 5-Year Run

CBI linking 2026 NEET-UG leak to NTA insiders intensified criticism of agency's functioning under Pradhan

Anubhuti Vishnoi

New Delhi: Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as education minister brings to a close a five-year tenure (2021-26) riddled with controversies, particularly in his second stint after the 2024 elections.

Within days of Pradhan taking charge again as education minister on June 9, 2024, reports emerged from Bihar of a NEET-UG paper leak. Even as the issue subsided after government assurances, it simmered over next two years, only to erupt with 2026 leak, impacting over 22 lakh students. Much of this has to do with the slow pace of

implementing the Radhakrishnan panel's recommendations to reform NEET-UG exam system and NTA.

While the health ministry has dithered over shifting the medical exam to a computer-based format, the NTA, under the Pradhan-led ministry's watch, has remained poorly led and staffed ever since the 2024 leak. The result: the 2026 leak, which CBI now traces to NTA insiders. Beyond NEET-UG, even as Pradhan successfully steered the implementation of NEP 2020, his second stint was marked by a series of controversies. Factor this: even as the ministry grappled with NEET-UG leak and exam cancellation row, it announced in May a surprise decision making it

compulsory for CBSE students from Class IX onwards to study three languages mid-session. The issue reached the SC, but before the court could rule on it, strong public backlash forced the CBSE to withdraw the order. Add to that, the serious public backlash over the poorly effected and suddenly introduced On Screen Marking system for class 12 board assessments this year on which is now under review. These rollbacks came barely months after NCERT withdrew a chapter from the new Class VIII textbooks over references on corruption and judiciary.

In February 2026, the SC stayed the UGC draft Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions Regu-

lations, 2026, which had sparked protests across states, including BJP-ruled ones, and ignited a political debate over provisions on penalties for "false complaints" of discrimination.

Two months before SC stay, the ministry had found itself in serious political crosshairs after its October 28, 2025 notification proposing restructuring of Panjab University's Senate and Syndicate prompted opposition from political parties in Punjab, and student and teacher bodies. On November 7, 2025, the ministry rolled back the notification. Earlier in 2025, another UGC proposal—draft UGC (Minimum Qualifications for Appointment and Promotion of Teachers) Regulations, 2025,

issued on January 6—also ran into opposition over a clause empowering Chancellors (Governors) to appoint the chairperson of the selection committee for VCs of state universities.

Amid the backlash, the Centre extended the deadline for public comments to the end of February 2025 and has since continued processing suggestions, effectively leaving the regulations in limbo. The string of controversies also claimed several top officials in the ministry, from NTA Director General after 2024 leak to CBSE Chairman in June 2026 and, most recently, Higher Education Secretary earlier this week.

Their minister now joins that list.

Prioritising larger interests, his decision to step down reflects the highest standards of integrity and selfless service in public life. The party stands firmly with Shri Dharmendra Pradhanji in this decision

NITIN NABIN
BJP president

True leadership is measured over decades & and Dr Dharmendra Pradhan-ji's journey stands as a testament to lifelong engagement with public life and student welfare

KIREN RIJJU
Parliamentary Affairs Minister

TERROR MODULE Assam STF Nabs 3 Linked to Pak's Bhatti Network

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: The Special Task Force (STF) of Assam Police on Saturday said it has unearthed a terror module linked to the Pakistan-based Shahzad Bhatti network and arrested three alleged operatives in the state. The STF conducted a coordinated operation on Friday with the assistance of district police of Dhubri, Chirang and Barpeta.

During the operation, the STF apprehended Akramul Islam from Dhubri, Aminur Rahman from Chirang, and Abdul Hussain from Barpeta," police said. Police added the operation also resulted in the seizure of five mobile phones, seven SIM cards, Aadhaar cards, bank passbooks, debit cards and other incriminating documents.

The operation was launched based on credible intelligence regarding the activities of the Shahzad Bhatti Network, a Pakistan-based terrorist-criminal network, involved in recruitment, online radicalisation, reconnaissance, logistics, espionage, illegal procurement of arms, establishment of sleeper cells, and

facilitation of terrorist activities in different parts of the country, police said.

According to the investigation and intelligence inputs forming part of the case, the network is alleged to operate in association with and under the directions of ISI through Pakistan-based handlers and encrypted communication channels.



The network is alleged to operate in association with and under the directions of ISI

IRDAI Chairman Wants Affordable Insurance for All

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The goal of 'Insurance for All' means insurance products which are available, accessible and affordable, said Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) chairman Ajay Seth.

The public needs full transparency and there is a need for informed consent, he said. "The authority's understanding of 'insurance for all' is that the product should be available, it should be accessible, and it should be affordable for the needs and the budget of different segments of the economy, different segments of the society and all parts of the country," Seth said at an Insurance Brokers Association of India (IBA) event on Saturday.

Transparency is the best solution for challenges, he said, adding, "The second would be the right incentive or the right disincentive. So incentives which are linked to the quality of sales, not just the volume."

HIGHEST-EVER QUARTERLY PROFIT IN JUNE

IDFC First Bank Q1 Profit Tops ₹1,000 Cr

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Private sector lender IDFC First Bank reported its highest-ever quarterly profit in June, with the bottom-line more than doubling to ₹1,075 crore, aided by strong growth in net interest income (NII) and lower provisions.

Net profit at the lender was Rs 463 crore in the same quarter last year. NII, the difference between interest earned and interest paid, increased 21% YoY to Rs 5,972 crore from ₹4,933 crore a year earlier.

Return on Assets (ROA) for the quarter improved to 1.06%, compared to 0.54% in Q1FY26. Net Interest Margin (NIM) rose to 5.96% in the June quarter from 5.71% a year earlier, up 25 basis points year-on-year.

"We are seeing strong business momentum. Our provisions as a percentage of loans continue to

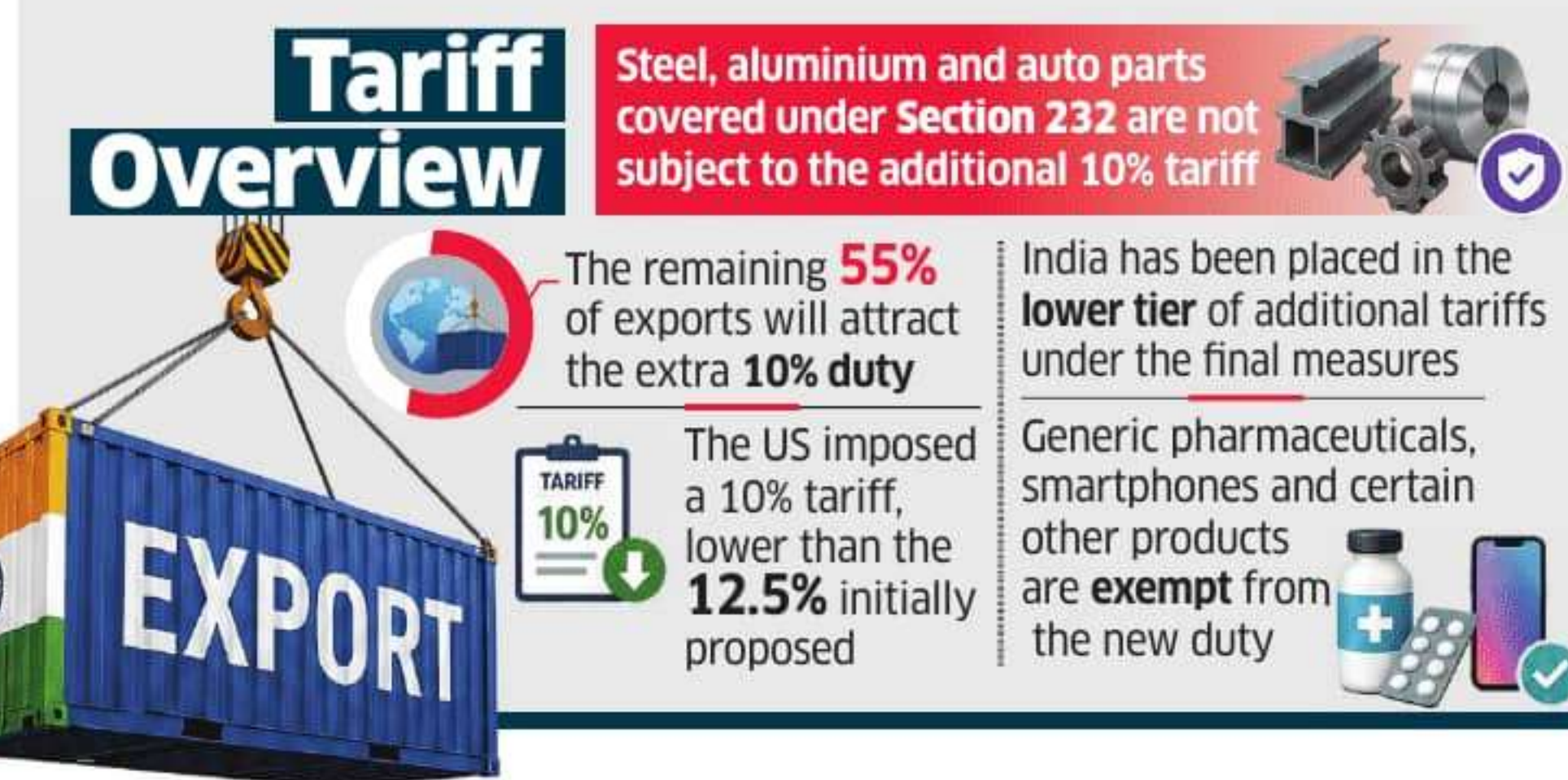
INDIA EXPORTED GOODS WORTH \$87.3 B TO US IN FY26

45% of US Exports Out of Section 301 Duty; Textile Mechanism Still Pending, Says Govt

Our Bureau

New Delhi: About 45% of India's exports to the US are excluded from the 10% additional tariffs imposed by the latter under its Section 301 measures on alleged forced labour concerns, the government said Saturday.

A textile specific mechanism—referred in the final measures—is yet to be set up, and New Delhi is continuing to engage with Washington on the issue, as part of ongoing negotiations for a bilateral trade agreement, the commerce and industry ministry said in a statement. India's exported goods worth \$87.3 billion to the US in FY26. "The remaining 55% of exports will attract the additional 10% duty, where India's tariff incidence is comparatively lower than that for most other economies covered by the investigation," the ministry said. The US Trade Representative (USTR) Thursday anno-



unced the final measures under Section 301 of the US Trade Act, 1974 wherein it imposed an additional 10% ad valorem duty on imports from India, lower than the 12.5% duty initially proposed on June 2.

The Indian government remained "closely engaged" with USTR throughout the investigation through detailed written submissions and in-person consultations, inclu-

ding participation in public hearings, per the statement.

"As a result of these sustained efforts, India has been placed in the lower tier of additional tariffs under the final measures, providing a relative advantage to Indian exporters in key sectors," the ministry said. A substantial share of India's exports to the US, which currently don't attract any additional duties, such as generic pharmaceuticals,

smartphones, and certain other specified products, and products already covered under Section 232 measures, including steel, aluminium and auto parts, are not subject to the additional 10% duty. Section 232 duties are applicable broadly to all countries with limited exceptions.

The Gem and Jewellery Export Promotion Council (GJEPC) rejected any implication that India's gem and jewellery sector is linked to forced labour, while highlighting that the 10% tariff provides Indian exporters with a 2.5 percentage-point tariff advantage over several competing manufacturing and trading hubs, including China and Hong Kong, all of which are now subject to a 12.5% additional tariff. However, the new tariff will pose challenges for Indian exporters, particularly as key competing diamond trading centres, such as in the EU and Africa, continue to enjoy duty-free access for natural diamonds, GJEPC said.

PhonePe FY26 Losses Surge 62% to ₹2,792 crore, Revenue Up 11%

Our Bureau

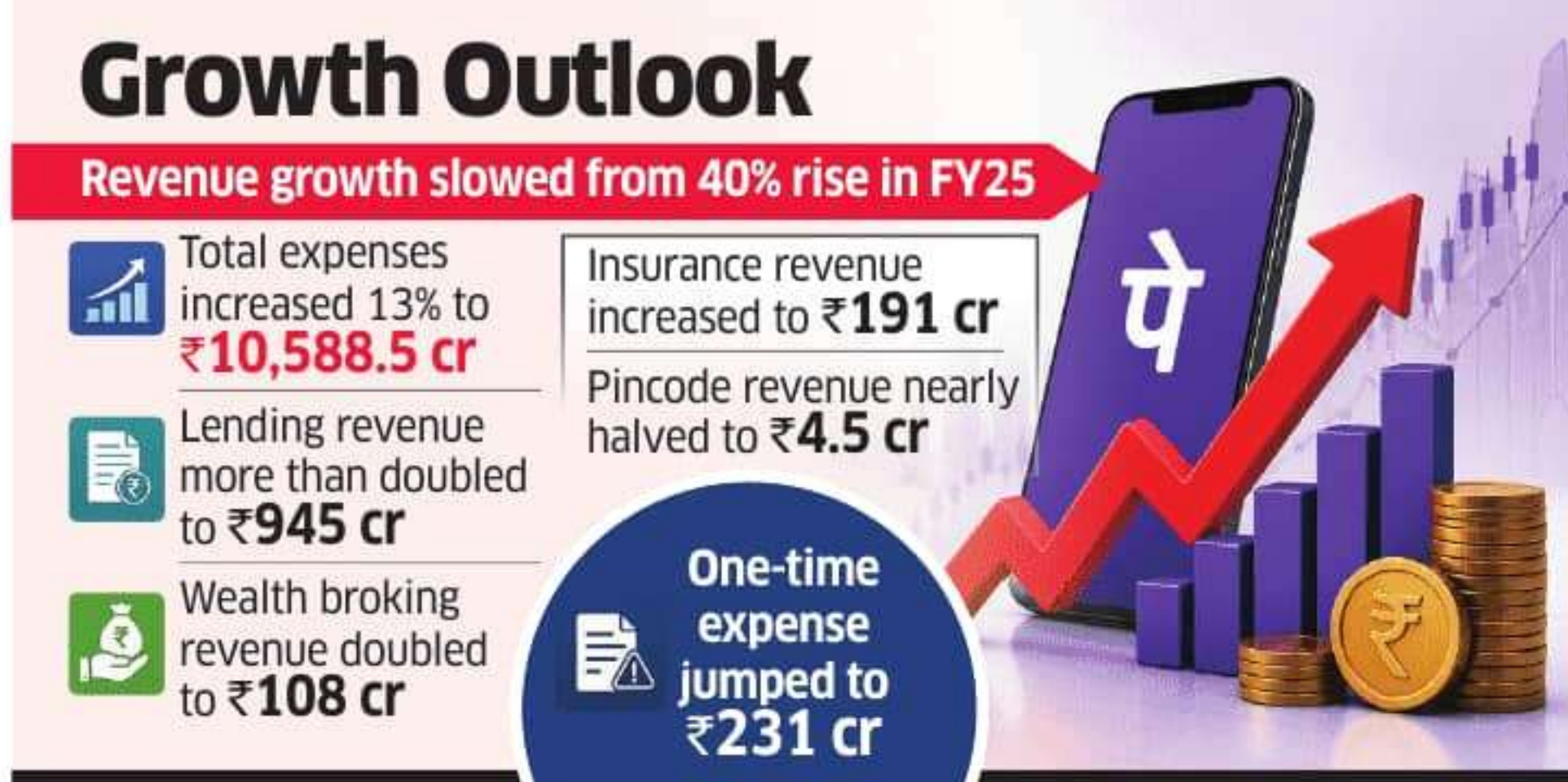
Bengaluru: Walmart-owned fintech firm PhonePe reported a 62% increase in net loss last fiscal year at ₹2,792 crore, impacted by higher expenses and a sharp slowdown in revenue growth.

Operating revenue grew 11% to ₹7,920 crore in FY26, slowing from a 40% rise the year before, and 74% growth in FY24, showed regulatory filings sourced from Tofler.

Total expenses rose 13% to ₹10,588.5 crore, primarily due to higher other expenses, including advertising costs.

Among PhonePe's units, its lending business displayed stronger performance last fiscal year, along with the wealth broking and insurance arms.

The lending subsidiary recorded a more than twofold surge in revenue to ₹945 crore in FY26 from ₹377.6 crore in the previous year, while the wealth broking arm more than doubled its revenue to ₹108 crore. The insurance arm's reve-



nue rose to Rs 191 crore from ₹180 crore during the period.

PhonePe's hyperlocal shopping app Pincode, which shut its business-to-commerce (B2C) operations last December, posted a revenue of ₹4.5 crore in FY26, nearly halving from the previous year. The company had said it will focus exclusively on expanding its business-to-business (B2B) business solutions for offline shops.

PhonePe also recorded a one-time

expense of Rs 231 crore last fiscal, much higher than Rs 27 crore a year earlier.

In March, the company announced deferring its proposed \$1.3 billion initial public offering amid pricing concerns, volatile markets, and geopolitical tensions.

PhonePe had received investor interest for an IPO worth around \$7 billion, about 50% lower than its last ascribed valuation, ET reported earlier.

South India Emerges as Key Hub for Hospitality Industry

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: South India is emerging as a major hotspot for the hospitality and tourism industry, buoyed by rising travel demand, especially to emerging destinations and religious sites, and tourism-friendly policies of states such as Andhra Pradesh.

The acquisition of Zuri resort in Kumarakom, Kerala, by ITC Hotels, and Leela's takeover of a luxury resort in Coorg, Karnataka, this year are instances of robust industry focus on this market. Sattva Group, which is targeting a soft launch of its Taj-branded resort in North Bengaluru, in partnership with Indian Hotels & Company Ltd in early 2027, is "actively" evaluating opportunities across Chennai, Hyderabad, and Visakhapatnam.

The company is also exploring select luxury boutique properties in



smaller hill stations across South India, where experiential travel is seeing increasing demand, said Adrijia Agarwal, president, Sattva Group. It is also developing a Trident hotel at BIAL aerospace park, close to the Bengaluru airport, to serve the rapidly expanding aerospace and business ecosystem in the region.

Agarwal said travel is no longer limited to solely for business or annual holidays. "People are travelling more frequently, spending more on experiences and cele-

brating life's milestones in increasingly meaningful ways," she said. "Weddings, wellness, entertainment, weekend getaways and curated experiences are becoming major demand drivers." Amusement and theme park operator Wonderla Holidays opened boutique resort Isle by Wonderla last year, besides revamping an existing property. "Hospitality is an adjacent business to running theme parks," said Arun K Chittilappilly, executive chairman and MD, Wonderla Holidays.

AU Small Fin Bank Q1 Net Rises 37% to ₹796 crore

Our Bureau

Kolkata: AU Small Finance Bank reported a 37% increase in first-quarter net profit to ₹796 crore over ₹581 crore a year ago, backed by improved asset quality, normalisation of unsecured loans and healthy business growth.

The Jaipur-headquartered lender, which is transitioning to a universal bank, on Saturday also announced the elevation of chief operating officer Yogesh Jain to deputy chief executive officer to strengthen its leadership.

Its pre-provision operating profit rose 9% year-on-year to ₹1435 crore, supported by a 32% surge in net interest income to ₹2,695 crore while a 97% fall in treasury earnings pulled other income down 15% to ₹689 crore. Net interest margin for the quarter to June stood at 5.9%, up 47 basis points from the year-ago period.

Prudent Corp Profit up 26%

MUMBAI: Mutual fund distributor Prudent Corporate Advisory's consolidated net profit rose by 26.5% to ₹74.8 crore for the quarter ended June 30, from ₹59.1 cr in the previous quarter. Its consolidated revenue from operations stood at ₹347.6 cr. **Our Bureau**

GOVT AIMS TO ADOPT BALANCED APPROACH: CM

'Arunachal won't Rush Siang Dam Study Amid China's Medog Project'

Shantanu Nandan Sharma

Itanagar: The Arunachal Pradesh government has decided not to rush the pre-feasibility study for the proposed mega hydropower project on the Siang River, which is seen as important to India's strategic and energy interests. Chief minister Pema Khandu told ET the state aims to adopt a balanced approach, addressing the concerns of families likely to be affected by the project before proceeding.

Siang is known as the Brahmaputra in Assam and the Yarlung Zangbo in China.

The proposed project, officially called the Siang Upper Multipurpose Project, is seen as a counter to China's construction of a giant dam on the same river at Medog, just across the McMahon Line.

Although hydropower producer NHPC moved drilling rigs and other heavy equipment to the site

in early 2025, the proposed ₹1.5 lakh-crore project has made little headway because of sporadic anti-dam protests, some of which have recently turned violent. "We do not want to rush a matter of such importance," Khandu said, adding that consultations with families likely to be affected by the project would continue. "My effort is to find a balanced and responsible way forward—one that protects the national interest while respecting the sentiments, concerns and aspirations of the people."

He said a project of this scale must move forward through participation, transparency and due process. "It cannot be imposed (on the people). It has to be explained." The chief minister, however, reiterated the strategic significance of the project, which has been designated a "national project" by the Centre. He said it

Why Siang Project Matters

Strategic response to China's mega dam on the Yarlung

Intended to strengthen India's water and energy security

Among India's biggest proposed hydropower projects

This project must be seen in the larger context of India's water security, energy security and long-term national interest, especially in view of developments upstream in Tibet...but it cannot be imposed. It has to be explained.

PEMA KHANDU Chief Minister, Arunachal Pradesh

should not be viewed merely as a hydropower venture.

"It must be seen in the larger context of India's water security, energy security and long-term national interest, especially in view of developments upstream in Tibet," Khandu said, in an apparent reference to China's construction of a massive dam on the river across the border.

He said more than 2,000 households across 48 villages in Siang and Upper Siang districts have given their consent for pre-feasibility-related activities.

Khandu, who earlier this week completed 10 years as Arunachal Pradesh's chief minister, said hydropower remains central to the state's development strategy, with projects totalling 19 gigawatts and involving investments of nearly Rs 1.9 lakh crore at various stages of development.

FOR FULL REPORT, GO TO www.economicstimes.com

'REEL REVOLUTION'

Gen Z Uses Short-Form Videos to Document, Spread Protest Message

Tanya Pandey

New Delhi: "Get Ready With Me to Get Beaten Up by the Police." "So bad, even the privileged are here!" "Kuchhu puchu, tum kahan ho? Please resign kar do." "Police uncle: Ek danda laga do!" A parody of the hit Punjabi song Dil Luteya, rewritten as Desh Luteya. Protesters dressed as giant cockroaches. Videos of police chasing students edited to the soundtrack of Subway Surfers.

A week ago, these may have sounded like unrelated internet memes. Today, they are among the most shared moments from the student protests that spilled from Delhi's Jantar Mantar onto Instagram Reels and YouTube



Shorts, turning social media into one of the movement's biggest stages.

At Jantar Mantar, phones are almost as common as placards. Students record, film slogans, sit on pavements editing videos and finding ways to upload them amid internet shutdowns and patchy connectivity. Every chant, parody, and confrontation is captioned and shared almost instantly. For years,

endless scrolling has been blamed for shrinking attention spans, particularly among Gen Z. The protests, however, present an interesting contrast. Instead of watching a 20-minute speech or a lengthy political debate, many young people are stitching together the movement through multiple short videos. The attention span may be shorter, but the curiosity has simply shifted to a different format. "People haven't stopped paying attention," said Smita Upadhyaya, a Delhi-based behavioural researcher. "They've changed the way they pay attention. Instead of investing 20 minutes in one video, they consume the same issue through multiple short pieces of content. Those pieces add up

to a much richer understanding than we often assume." Humour is often the hook. A parody song, a witty placard or a satirical skit makes people stop scrolling. The explanation comes next. One reel explains why students demanded education minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. Another captures conversations from the protest site. Others document journeys of students travelling from different parts of the country to Delhi. Individually, each clip offers only a glimpse. Together, they help viewers understand what the movement is about. "Our generation lives on Instagram," said Aashita Agrawal, a 21-year-old student participating in the protest.

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Sonali Kokra

We are in Ruchi's childhood home in Mumbai. It is low-ceilinged, cheerless and badly in need of repair. The walls carry the sour stench of rainwater and the windows look like they haven't been cracked open in months. It's not the kind of place one would invite a stranger to but none of that seems to register with Ruchi. In the hour that we spend together, her eyes flit to a door that's slightly ajar. Every few minutes, we hear low grunting sounds from within. They punctuate the topic that has brought us together that afternoon: death. And the ominous, soul-crushing expectation of it.

Ruchi's father is fading fast. His oncologist no longer uses the vocabulary of months. I send a silent prayer heavenward when I hear that: "Please, god, not while I'm here." Shamefully self-absorbed? Without a doubt. I do not want to witness the moment a person becomes an orphan.

What strikes me about Ruchi is how preternaturally calm she is. She describes the last six months of her life: quitting her job to take care of her father, his decision to stop treatment, their methodical transfer of assets. Her clinical approach to death is puzzling, even for her. "You know the people who have embarrassing public meltdowns at the thought of a parent dying? I was that person. But when it's actually happening, I have a checklist. It feels anticlimactic and wrong. Like I'm a bad daughter."

At 40, Ruchi can't pinpoint why the fear of her father's mortality has colonised her life for over three decades. An only child of divorced parents, she has no memory of her mother. Both her grandparents were healthy and lived well into their 80s. If anything, she's among the lucky ones, never having confronted prolonged suffering until now. And yet, she remembers feeling her chest tighten like it was going to explode while watching Mufasa die in *The Lion King* on her eighth birthday. "I'm fairly certain it was my first panic attack," she tells me. "I was convinced that my father, too, would die suddenly one day and I'd be all alone. That feeling has never really left me."

ARE THEY OKAY?

Swagatika Sarangi, 30, from Bengaluru and 26-year-old Pratik Goel (name changed) from Delhi can relate, but for wildly different reasons.

In 2016, Sarangi was diagnosed with obsessive compulsive disorder (OCD) due to her relentless and entirely unfounded fear that her parents would suddenly drop dead. "I'd start spiralling if they missed my calls for any reason," she admits. "We've now installed cameras in the common areas of our home, so I can see they are okay instead of panicking immediately."

On the other end of the spectrum is Goel, haunted by financial ambiguity. He is the middle child, sandwiched between two sisters. He joined his father's business when he was 19. It's the only employment he's ever known. "Everything I've ever earned has gone back into the business. But the firm itself is in my father's name. And our houses are in my mother's name," he tells me. Death is a taboo subject in the Goel family, and it is unlikely that his parents have drawn up any wills, let alone registered ones. "If they were to die tomorrow, my sisters can claim 'equal share', despite never having earned a rupee for the business or contributing a rupee towards my parents' expenses. How is that fair?" The one time he tried to broach the topic, he was accused of "waiting for them to die". He claims that the family dynamic has changed irrevocably since this catastrophic fight three years ago. "All I wanted was clarity." Bracing for a long and bitter legal battle in the future, Goel has retained legal counsel and maintains extensive documentation to support his eventual claims.

MORBID PREOCCUPATION

For all its attendant terror, death is maddeningly mundane. All the breathless carpe diem-ing life advice we have ever been assaulted with is triaged around the certainty that someday we and everyone we know and love (or despise) is going to be dead. Death, one might argue, is a load-bearing conviction. Without it, life collapses. We strive to achieve immortality through our work, words and deeds because there is no denying death. It is compulsory for physical forms.

Why, then, does thinking of it in relation to our own parents terrorise us so? And is every generation cursed with this harrowing fixation on parental death when they reach middle age? Or, are today's grown-up 'kids' more morbidly consumed by it than their predecessors?

Seema Hingorani, a clinical psychologist from Mumbai, believes it is the latter. According to her, while the idea of a parent dying is "unsettling, no

The Fear Before the Grief

The death of a parent is one of life's oldest certainties. Yet for many millennials and Gen Z adults, it is an all-consuming preoccupation. They monitor parents' heart rates from continents away, stock medicine cabinets and postpone careers, trying to outrun the inevitable—all the while dreading the moment they cease to be someone's child and become the generation at the front of the line

People are making radical life changes to be closer to parents in their twilight years. Many gave up dream jobs or promotions. Some ended relationships. A few became caregivers



aunts and uncles would step in to fill the 'elderly influence' vacuum." Marriage doesn't guarantee partnership. People choose not to marry or opt out of unhappy ones all the time. "When you don't have a partner, it's natural to be more emotionally dependent on parents."

And, finally, making everything infinitely worse is the longevity industrial complex, where success often depends on the vicious exploitation of our most primal vulnerabilities. Pills, potions, proteins, peptides, drugs, diagnostics, dubious 'discoveries', therapies, treatments, tools, technologies... Billions and billions of dollars dedicated to the pursuit of beating biology. In January, the Consumer Electronics Show 2026 saw big and small names in health tech hawking devices focused on complex metabolic markers. No longer satisfied with just tracking heart rate, blood pressure and glucose levels, they now want to drown us with insights gleaned from hormones, blood, pee, saliva, sperm and even foot sweat, it seems. Another burgeoning—and even more pricey—category at the show was at-home elderly care bots to keep ageing and (ostensibly lonely) parents company, dispense precise combinations of pills, remind them to take medicines and alert you when they don't.

CARE FROM AFAR

London-based Nihal KG, 43, acknowledges that he's trapped and unlikely to escape. He has outfitted his parents' home in Noida with AI-enabled motion sensors that analyse movement patterns to detect and even predict imbalance or falls. This is in addition to the powders and supplements he sends them every few weeks, which is in addition to their Ultrahuman rings, Apple Watches and a battery of blood tests they have to get done every month.

"It costs me ₹18-20 lakh a year," Nihal admits. "It's probably excessive, but it's a small price to pay for peace of mind since they won't move to London and I can't be there to take care of them."

"We keep finding ways to do more to keep our parents alive so we don't regret anything later," says Hingorani. "We have instant access to information, constant guilt that we have not been 'good enough' children to our parents and the ability to afford the interventions that suddenly seem crucial. We do more but are still always miserable. What's the point?"

Almost everyone I spoke to had stories about silently making radical life changes so they could be closer to their parents in their twilight years. Many had given up dream jobs, promotions, or lucrative opportunities away from home. Some had ended relationships. A few had become default caregivers so their siblings would never have to make the same compromises.

US & THEM

Juxtaposed against these decisions are some thorny questions: What does it mean to live authentically and honour our own selves while building healthy relationships with our parents? How do we show up for them without being tormented by resentment while they are alive and regret once they are gone? Perhaps the point is simply to buy ourselves some time while we figure out the answers.

And maybe the point is that once we strip away the guilt, the checklists, the cameras and monitors and powders, what we are left with is this: our parents are the ultimate wall. The thing standing between us and the front of the line. As long as they are alive, however frail, however diminished, however infuriating, death is still happening to someone else's generation. The day they go, that wall comes crashing down, and there's nothing standing between us and the terrifying void except our own bodies, marching towards entropy.

There's a second aching isolation that nothing can truly prepare you for: when you lose a parent, you lose the person who has been narrating all the different versions of you back to yourself. Who you were as a child before you could remember, what makes you light up from the inside, why you flinch at certain things.

Parents, quite simply, are our personal living archives. When they go, we grieve them, yes, but we are also grieving the child that has lost its most faithful alibi. It's not just about missing them. It's about, at least in part, missing all the different versions of you who will now only exist in photographs and the unreliable narrations of people who weren't ever wholly there. And all the versions that you are still to become, but might never have witnesses.

Maybe that's why Ruchi has a checklist instead of a meltdown. Maybe the calm is simply dread in age-appropriate clothing, helping her be a good daughter—one last time.

Sonali Kokra is a Mumbai-based writer

TALK MONEY

Map the Finances: List assets, liabilities and income sources

Check for a Will: Even a handwritten will, signed by two witnesses, is legally recognised; registration makes it easier to enforce

If You Are A Woman Whose Parents Manage Your Money: List what is in your name, check what you have signed

(guarantor/co-borrower status) and review your investments

Fix Account Access: Link your own phone number and email, not your parents', with your investments

Use Account Aggregators: They will help you trace holdings you are unaware of

Source: Shilpa Gole, Partner, NerdyBird Wealth Advisory

matter what", the anxiety that millennials and Gen Z are feeling is worrisome. "They've thought about it so obsessively that they expect to completely fall apart when it happens," Hingorani attributes this dread to a volatile mix of emotions, existential angst and the extremely disorienting economic landscape we are being forced to navigate.

"Family is the primary social unit and source of identity in India, at least for now," says Hingorani. "The thought of parents dying is immediately followed by, 'Who will be in my corner now? Who will prioritise me? How will I manage alone?'" It's not hard to see how these can be destabilising questions in an increasingly lonely world. This is compounded by the reality of rapidly shrinking families. "For previous generations,

Book, a Treatment

Nupur Amarnath

In Satoshi Yagisawa's bestselling *Days at the Morisaki Bookshop*, Takako retreats to her eccentric uncle's second-hand bookstore in Tokyo's Jimbocho to nurse a heart-break. Living among dusty shelves and quiet routines, she rediscovers reading. She muses: "I think every serious reader at some point in their life encounters a book like that. And they never forget the experience."

For Mumbai-based book blogger and marketer Vidhya A Thakkar, that book was Michiko Aoyama's *Hot Chocolate on Thursday*. "I discovered these books during a low phase of my life in 2024. I couldn't concentrate enough to read a full novel. These were not only my way back into reading but also part of my healing journey."

Bengaluru-based auditor Nishtha Sikka was initially drawn in for practical reasons: they were short, easy to read, with intriguing covers and titles like *Letters From The Ginza Shihodo Stationery Shop*. "What keeps me

coming back is the positivity, nostalgia and sense of belonging I get when I read these books. There's a pattern: ordinary days, food, small problems that resolve gently, community, a listening ear and usually one guiding character."

ALL LIT UP

In an interview with The Nod during his visit to the Kerala Literature Festival this year, Yagisawa said he writes "these stories as an answer to a noisy world. My hope is that readers can use my work as a refuge". Thakkar found exactly that: "They aren't self-help books, but they help you heal. I felt the books found me at the right time."

She isn't alone. Healing fiction—also marketed as UpLit, comfort fiction, or cosy reads—is one of publishing's fastest-growing genres, proving that sometimes a book can work as a balm.

For publishers, this is no longer a niche. Poulomi Chatterjee, executive publisher and rights director at HarperCollins India, says readers are turning to stories that offer emotional refuge. "Themes such as kindness, second chances, found family and quiet hope answer that need. We've seen a shift towards character-led stories that stay with the readers long after the last page," she says.

Alongside international titles like *What You Are Looking for* is in *The Library*, *Days at the Torunka Cafe* and *The Vanishing Cherry Blossom Bookshop*, there are Indian novels such as *Stuti Changle's Stars Will Guide You Home*. "Publishers are certainly acquiring more comfort fiction

because readers are actively seeking it." The focus, however, remains a good story, not a trend.

Booksellers are seeing the demand too. Rachna Chopra of Mumbai's KitabKhana, a self-confessed fan of the genre, has watched healing fiction find readers across generations. She loves its observational prose with kindness at its core. "It makes you reflect, appreciate and slow down. When I picked *Welcome to the Hyunam-Dong Bookshop* for our book club, one reader said this book saved their life. The books remind us that healing can be found in everyday moments."

What binds these books together is

What is UpLit
Uplifting Literature started as a publishing category for novels that leave readers feeling optimistic and emotionally satisfied

What's New
Iyashikei, or healing fiction, which is a Japanese genre focused on emotional restoration through quiet, everyday stories. A lot of Japanese and Korean books in this genre have been translated

less plot than the feeling they leave behind. Kunzum founder Ajay Jain says readers look for something main-stream fiction often bypasses. He identifies three ingredients. First, they are set in insulated, quiet micro-spaces like bookstores or cafes, they are an antidote to the busy city hustle. Second, they provide low-stakes emotional safety, minus the hijinks of most fiction. Finally, they celebrate the sanctity of small routines—smell of old books, freshly brewed coffee and rain on a windowpane. "By elevating these small ordinary things into something sacred, they remind the reader that a good life doesn't need grand, exhausting achievements."

PAPERBACK HAS GOT YOUR BACK

The appeal extends beyond sales into reading communities. At The Indian Book Club, members now recommend healing fiction as "a legit genre". Founder Divya Jain says these books spark a different kind of conversation. "Instead of focusing on plot twists or suspense, members talk about emotions, favourite moments and how the stories made them feel. The discussions are often quieter." At Bandra Reads, *Days at the Morisaki Bookshop* drew one of the club's biggest turnouts. Founder Amie Fazulbhai says, "Many of our members are young professionals juggling demanding jobs. There's very little time to sit with their emotions. These books help with that."

That emotional connection is precisely what makes the genre work, says London-based bibliotherapist, counsellor and author Bijal Shah. "These

stories create a gentle emotional space in which readers can sit with difficult feelings without being overwhelmed. They allow emotions to be explored at a safe distance, while offering connection, reflection and hope," she says. She adds that literary fiction can be particularly valuable during periods of transition such as bereavement, burnout, divorce and retirement.

The settings matter, too. "Nostalgic settings such as bookshops, cafes and libraries are powerful because they evoke familiarity, belonging and emotional safety," says Shah.

Psychologist Namrata Upadhyay says while these books cannot replace psychotherapy, their popularity mirrors a wider shift in how people are approaching mental health and emotional resilience. "People are seeking resources that help them understand emotions, cultivate resilience and feel less alone. This genre may approach these themes without becoming overtly instructional that can feel less prescriptive and personally meaningful."

Sikka says: "Such books slow you down on purpose. The stories are a warm hug for anyone who needs it." And sometimes, a hug is all one needs.

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Narco East



The Northeast, a major transit route for drugs, has become the victim as well, with heroin addiction taking hold of communities on the Assam-Arunachal border

5 THINGS RECOVERING USERS SAY:

- Drugs are easily available
- Brown sugar often leads to heroin
- Heroin is far more expensive
- Deals are done in cash
- Children are the biggest motivation for quitting drugs

DRUGS INTERCEPTED (Data for 2025)

1.3 lakh kilo	265	116	₹665 cr
Volume of drugs seized in India, valued at around ₹2,000 cr	No. of convicted narcotics offenders, including nine foreign nationals	No. of traffickers arrested in Northeast	Value of drugs seized in NE

Source: NCB

INSIDE THE CHINTUANG DRUG NETWORK

WHO IS CHINTUANG?

Thancintuang alias Chintuang is a Myanmar-based drug kingpin who was arrested in Delhi in May. His network is a major supplier of heroin and methamphetamine

ASSOCIATES

- VUNGKHAHTHAWNA, key facilitator
- LALRAMPARI, hawala operator; ₹100 crore transactions under probe
- ABU SALEH, logistics coordinator in Assam
- JABRUL, Tripura-Assam transporter

Source: NCB

Shantanu Nandan Sharma | Oyan (Arunachal Pradesh), Jonai (Assam)

In 2017, Yano (name changed) was a Class IX student in Pasighat, Arunachal Pradesh, when a group of friends offered her something they promised would deliver an “intense high”. Curious, she smoked the brownish substance inside a small tobacco tin. Without a second thought, she handed over ₹500 to a peddler. She had no idea that the first puff would mark the beginning of a years-long battle with addiction.

Within days, Yano’s craving became overwhelming. Desperate for another hit, she started searching for the peddler. To her, brown sugar was simply a “foreign” drug — unlike kani (opium), the narcotic she had grown up hearing about.

For the next three years, until the Covid-19 pandemic, she was hooked on brown sugar—the impure, street form of heroin, often mixed with adulterants. Around 2020, she graduated to “a whitish powder that looked like Horlicks”—a far more potent and expensive drug. It was heroin, and this time she was injecting it.

Today, at 24, Yano has left narcotics behind after two rounds of residential treatment at a rehabilitation centre in Yingking, a town in Upper Siang district. Unemployed and estranged from her mom and two sisters, she is rebuilding her life.

“I am a recovering warrior,” she says with confidence. That phrase is more than a personal affirmation. It is also the name of a civil society group she has recently joined. Recovering Warriors is an yet-to-be registered organisation in Oyan, a small town in Arunachal Pradesh, about 12 km north of Murkongselek, the last railway station in north Assam and a locality widely regarded as a hotspot for drug trafficking.

Yano has a single mission: to ensure that the young do not walk the dark path that once consumed her.

DRUG ROUTE

Once viewed largely as a transit route for narcotics from the Golden Triangle of Myanmar, Laos and Thailand, Northeast India is now confronting a far more troubling reality: its own people are taking drugs. Arunachal Pradesh—particularly the districts along the

Siang River (known as the Brahmaputra in Assam)—has also been drawn into the crisis, although it lies outside the principal drug trafficking corridor that runs through Myanmar, Manipur, Mizoram, Assam and Tripura.

The scale of trafficking underscores the magnitude of the challenge. Last year, narcotics agencies arrested 116 traffickers across the Northeast and seized drugs worth about ₹665 crore.

It’s believed that these seizures are only the tip of the iceberg, and that a far larger volume of narcotics is slipping through the region’s borders.

Across the country, in 2025, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) seized 133,965 kg of narcotic drugs, with an estimated street value of ₹2,000 crore. Also, 265 offenders, including nine foreigners, were convicted, underscoring both the transnational nature of the trade and the intensifying enforcement efforts against it.

The arrest of two Myanmar-based drug kingpins—Thancintuang, better known as Chintuang, in Delhi in May, and Nengzatuan alias Tuanpi in Manipur’s Churachandpur earlier this week—exposed the layers of a sophisticated cross-border trafficking network. Investigators say the syndicate supplied methamphetamine and heroin from Myanmar to India through the Northeast, using an elaborate supply chain that stretched across the international border. According to NCB’s estimates, the illicit trafficking network anchored by Chintuang alone is valued at ₹115 crore.

PATH OF RECOVERY

Earlier this month, ET met more than a dozen former drug users along the Assam-Arunachal Pradesh border to understand how they were drawn into addiction, what it took to break free and how life changed from the depths of dependence to the difficult journey of recovery. They spoke candidly about the nexus between peddlers and users, the changing drugs landscape, the shifting prices of narcotics and the ease with which they are available.

The most disturbing takeaway is this: heroin has become alarmingly accessible across the belt. Former users say addiction has driven many to sell whatever they own—including family



Two recovering drug users from Jonai, Assam

A first-time buyer might call the peddler and say, ‘I’m waiting near such and such hotel, wearing a yellow T-shirt.’ The money changes hands, the drugs are delivered, and that’s it”
RECOVERING USER, 46, Jonai, Assam

farmland—to finance their next hit. When they run out of possessions, some even turn to loot, trapped in a cycle of craving and dependence.

The stories are as diverse as they are unsettling. Among those who spoke to this writer are graduates and postgraduates, a 46-year-old employee of Assam’s education department, a former accountant at a tea estate owned by the son of a former Arunachal Pradesh chief minister, and a man from Arunachal who says he “graduated from brown sugar to heroin” while pursuing a master’s degree in tourism in Shillong a few years ago.

Many describe themselves as poly-drug users. Their descent into addiction began with cannabis before progressing to brown sugar and, eventually, heroin.

“I switched to heroin because I wanted to prove to myself that I was smarter,” recalls one of them. “I had also convinced myself that heroin would work as an aphrodisiac.” The switch came at a steep price. “When I was taking brown sugar, ₹4,000 a week was enough. But after I shifted to heroin, I needed around ₹1,500 every day,” he says. The father of six-year-old twins, he has not touched drugs in the last two years of recovery.

The Assam government employee offers a glimpse into the mechanics of the drug trade. “Drugs don’t reach Jonai directly from Myanmar,” he says, referring to the Assam town that borders Arunachal Pradesh. “Consignments first reach distributors in larger hubs like Guwahati. If

someone in Jonai places an order worth ₹50,000-100,000, a peddler delivers it.”

According to him, the trade runs entirely on cash. Peddlers, he says, are often local residents who have “good connections” with distributors and brokers in the supply chain. The nature of the transaction is simple. “A first-time buyer might call a peddler and say, ‘I’m waiting near such and such hotel, wearing a yellow T-shirt.’ Money changes hands, drugs are delivered, that’s it.”

The ease and informality of the exchange, he says, have made narcotics remarkably accessible, even in small towns away from the international frontier.



The 24-year-old from Pasighat rebuilt her life after two rounds of treatment at a rehabilitation centre. “I am now a recovering warrior,” she says

Another recovering user from Arunachal Pradesh, a 35-year-old with two school-going daughters, says users in the region distinguish between two varieties of brown sugar. One, he says, is significantly more potent and is known as pagla (mad) brown sugar. “Once you take it, you lose control over yourself,” he says. “You don’t know what you are doing. People have assaulted others, committed robberies and there have been cases of users dying in road accidents while driving under its influence.”

He says addiction had distorted his sense of reality. “I became convinced that my wife was having an affair,” he recalls. “It was my imagination but it triggered constant arguments and nearly destroyed my family.”

ADDITION TO REHAB

For many who are battling addiction, recovery begins not in a rehabilitation centre but at home. Family support, says Tapir Darang, chief adviser to the All Arunachal Anti-Drugs Warriors, is often the most important factor in helping a user break free from the grip of narcotics.

“The biggest problem is families that are trying to hide someone’s addiction,” he says. “If they are unwilling to cooperate or seek help for the victim, we reach out to the clan chief. Their intervention can make a difference. It is important to get the user into a rehab centre.”

Darang says grassroots organisations

Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland remain less affected than several states in terms of overall narcotics enforcement indicators

are stepping in where families and institutions fall short. Among them is Recovering Warriors in Oyan, which he says is at the forefront of the fight against drug abuse in the Assam-Arunachal Pradesh border belt.

Founded only last year, the organisation has conducted anti-drug awareness programmes in 24 villages while also participating in flood relief operations. Its president, Mohan Tamut, believes recovery is about much more than detoxification.

“It is important for former drug users to have a community they can call their own,” says Tamut. “They play football, volleyball and badminton together. Quitting narcotics is never easy and staying away is even harder. Unless they remain connected and support one another, the risk of relapse is always there.”

Repeat offenders are required to sign a written undertaking that they will never return to narcotics, he adds.

Just as Oyan and Pasighat in Arunachal Pradesh receive narcotics via the Murkongselek railway belt in Assam, Wokha’s drug supply is routed through Merapani, another border town in Assam. In both places, drugs do not arrive directly from Myanmar although Arunachal

Pradesh and Nagaland share long international borders with the country.

While the Northeast, along with states such as Punjab and Rajasthan, is identified by the NCB as a major hotspot for heroin trafficking, it is important to place the region’s crisis in perspective. States such as Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland remain less affected than several other parts of the country in terms of overall narcotics enforcement indicators.

In 2024, for instance, law enforcement agencies across India seized more than 1 million kilograms of narcotic drugs. Arrests under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act were the highest in Kerala (24,517), followed by Punjab (9,734), according to a reply to a Lok Sabha question in February last year. By comparison, Arunachal Pradesh recorded 323 arrests and Nagaland 273.

The relatively modest numbers, however, should not be mistaken for a lesser threat. In sparsely populated, predominantly tribal hill states such as Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland, even a few hundred users can leave lasting scars on families and entire communities.

For many former users who are now parents, the greatest fear is no longer about relapsing. It is the possibility that their own children could one day follow the path they once did.

“One question haunted me every day,” says a 40-year-old former user from Oyan. “What if my children too start taking drugs? That fear pushed me to reclaim my life before it was too late.”

The real battle is no longer on the border, it is inside homes.

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Apoorva Mittal

Lying on a leather chair, Kampam Rampal Chhabra felt the upward gliding pressure of the aesthetician’s fingers on her face. The 34-year-old nutritionist from Bilaspur, Chhattisgarh, was trying facial yoga for the first time in Mumbai, where she was on her annual trip with her best friend. She felt the puffiness on her face melt away.

Chhabra, who had been asking her dermatologist to add a little more to her face routine “as we are not getting any younger”, chanced upon “face fitness” on her Instagram feed. It promised to lift and sculpt face muscles, even reduce fine lines and help with acne, with just hand movements, tools and muscle stimulation. This is anti-Botox, the other end of face care without invasive procedures. Chhabra’s treatment involved hand strokes, serums, packs and hot towels. “It was refreshing,” she says.

Face fitness or face yoga is targeted facial massage but the terms themselves feed into a world obsessing over wellness and exercise. It borrows the aspiration of aesthetic medicine, the ritual of skincare, the discipline of fitness and the language of wellness.

It is catching on at a time when the pressure to put one’s best face for-

ward in today’s hyper-visual world is deeply felt, when even GLP-1 drugs are increasingly spoken of in aesthetic terms.

FIX THE SKIN

Pooja Lalwani Tamang, founder of the facial workout studio Fit Face in Khar, Mumbai, says her customers include Gen Z, millennials, people over 50 and women in their 70s and 80s. Men account for 30-40% of her clientele. “A lot of people are getting very conscious of the way they look, face-wise and body-wise. Every time we introduce a new treatment, it is not like we have to really convince people to do it,” she says.

Farah Maneckshaw, therapist and founder of The Mirrored Room, a mental health initiative in Bengaluru, says clients are increasingly focusing on body image concerns, especially facial features. The anxiety, she says, is also shaped by a beauty culture that has moved away from makeup to skin, structure and a “natural” appearance. The language of fitness makes work on appearance sound less like vanity and more like discipline, she says. “Fitness, wellness and health are all used in a way that makes it a little bit more palatable. Wellness has become a catch-all phrase and fitness has become a way to

Saving Face

Face fitness, which borrows the ritual of skincare and the language of wellness, is taking off in this hyper-visual world

talk about these things and sell them in a way that is received better.”

Before face fitness became a studio service, it was a face ritual that one researched online and tried on oneself. Noida-based marketing professional Shivani Aggarwal came across the

concept a few years ago through the videos of Japanese face yoga instructor Koko Hayashi. That led Aggarwal to guasha which she incorporated into her night routine. “I could see a visible difference in a week’s time,” she says. “There was less water retention and

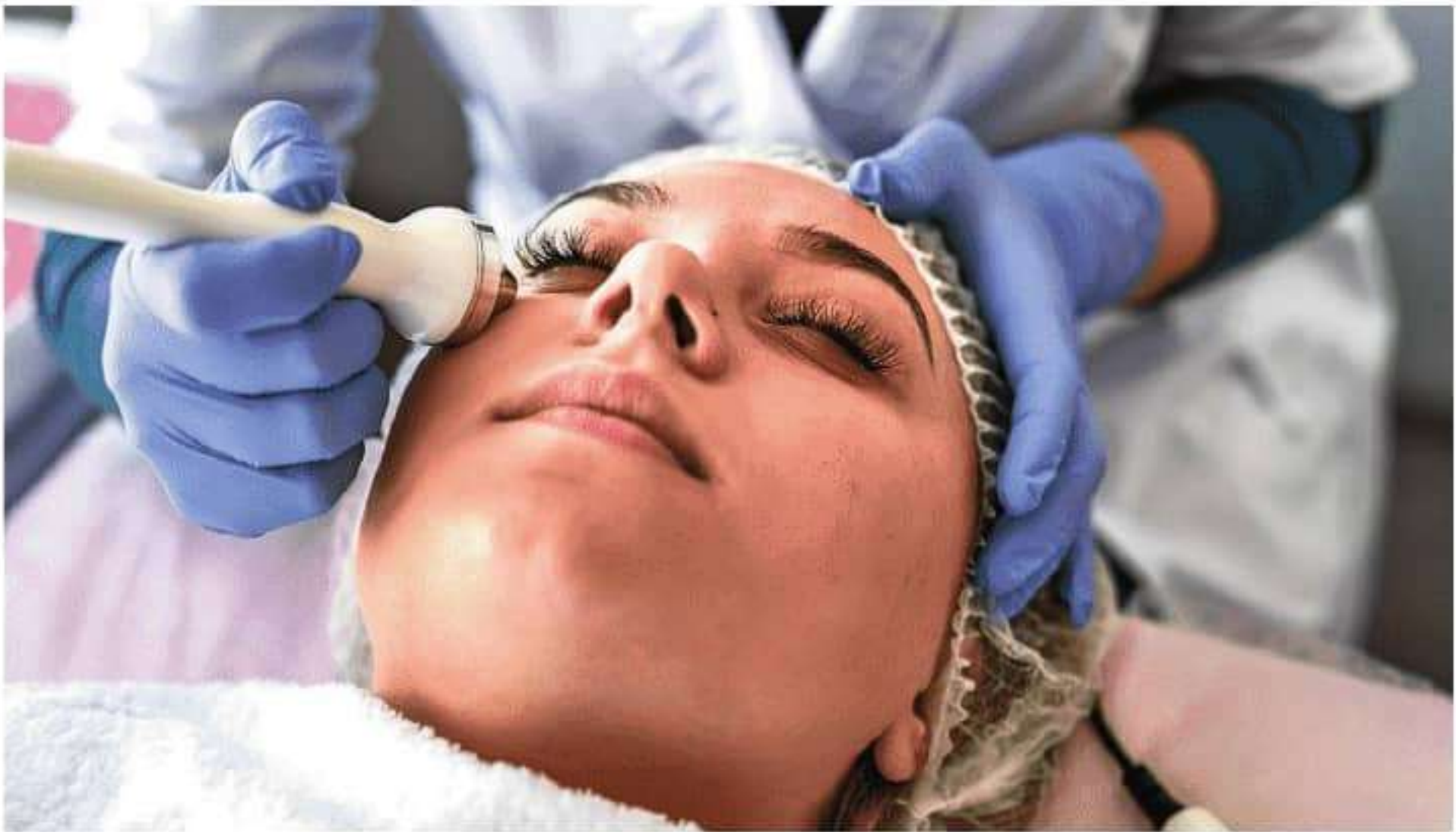
better blood circulation... my skin was glowing. And I got defined cheekbones and a jawline.” For her, the routine is as much about self-care as it is about appearance. “If I look good, I feel good. How healthy your skin is affects your mood and your lifestyle.”

CHANGING PHASES

The do-it-yourself ritual is evolving now. In India, global companies, homegrown beauty entrepreneurs and face yoga specialists are positioning it slightly differently—as a workout, a natural alternative, a preventive service, a preventative anti-ageing routine and a beauty maintenance habit.

FACEGYM, a UK-based facial fitness brand, is among those trying to formalise the category in India. It was launched in the country last month through a partnership with Reliance Retail. A company spokesperson says the brand looks at face the way fitness companies look at body. The company

The do-it-yourself ritual is evolving now. India has global companies, homegrown beauty entrepreneurs and face yoga specialists



WHAT IS FACE FITNESS?

Face fitness refers to non-invasive exercises and massage techniques that claim to improve circulation and firmness and reduce puffiness. The practice is marketed as a way to tone the face and soften signs of ageing

IS IT EFFECTIVE?

Small-scale studies suggest some potential benefits with consistent practice, but the evidence remains limited and preliminary

says it is not trying to replace facials, dermatology or aesthetic procedures, but to create a category centred on muscle activation and long-term facial fitness. Its core customer in India is an urban, premium beauty consumer, typically in the mid-20s to early 40s, who already spends on skincare, wellness and fitness. Women form a majority of the audience, but the brand says men are also showing growing interest in grooming and skincare.

Homegrown players say the category has been years in the making. Vibhuti Vohra Arora has been offering face yoga classes through House of Beauty

since 2018. She says by 2021-22, the Indian beauty consumer was ready to learn face yoga online and pay for therapist-led services.

“We saw a gap in the market between traditional salon facials and clinics where everything was machine-dependent, and hand motions were limited,” she says. House of Beauty launched its first physical space in 2022 and has since expanded its services to tier-1 and -2 cities, including Jaipur and Nagpur. This year she plans to open 15 centres that offer services like lymphatic drainage, facial cupping, microcurrent and LED therapy.

Face fitness is not growing in isolation. It is part of a wider movement where beauty, wellness, longevity and self-optimisation overlap. Sowmay Jain, founder of healthtech platform Zelta, recently hosted a lookmaxxing party in Mumbai complete with a nail bar, an astro corner and a peptide bar billed as “the frontier of glow-up”.

Meanwhile, Chhabra is careful not to overstate the results of face yoga. Having tried it twice, she says she cannot yet claim a visible transformation. But she wants to continue. “I wanted a bit of firmness on my face,” she says. “Maybe if I keep doing it for 6 or 10 months, I will see a bigger difference.”

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Does an Actor Really Need to Resemble the Public Figure He or She's Playing?

Many actors have played the same roles, enough for persona to fuse with impersonator—but what about when they take on the role of famous people, lack of belly belying authenticity notwithstanding?

FUNNY BUSINESS



ANUVAB PAL

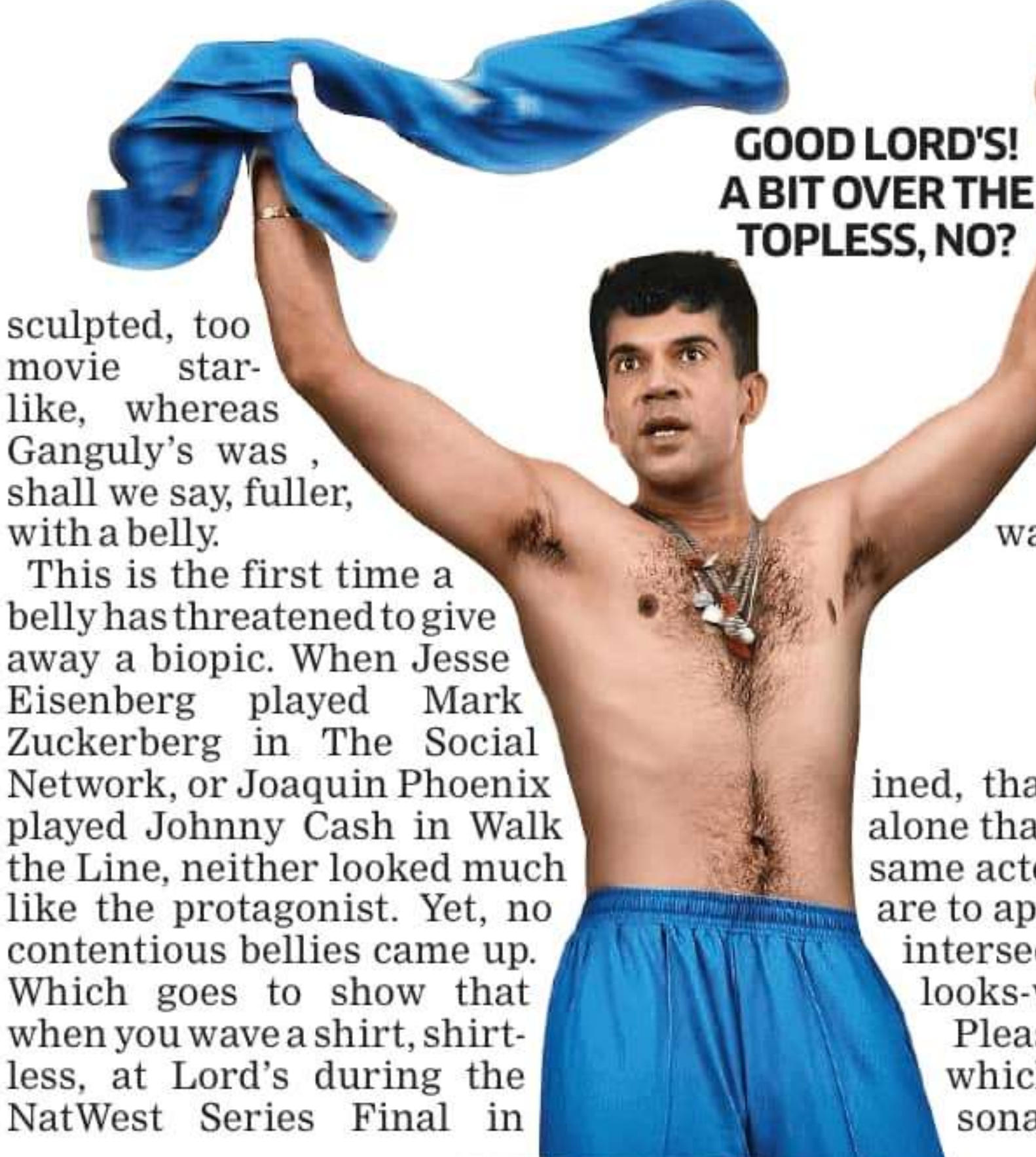
I ran into an actor friend of mine who told me she played Indira Gandhi 7 times in 4 different films in different languages. This got me thinking. What goes into the casting of a famous person? How many Mrs Gs are too many? Do you have to look like that person?

Bollywood is famous for legends about the same actor playing the same role. The most notable (perhaps untrue) nugget is about Iftekhar, who played a police commissioner so often in the 1970s-1980s that his kids thought he *was* one.

Recently, there's been a lot of talk about an upcoming biopic on Sourav Ganguly, titled, naturally, Dada. The publicity photo used is the iconic shirtless wave of the India captain's shirt from the Lord's balcony, shouting expletives—which, in one sense, defined the postcolonial end of Indian cricket's servitude to the Empire, and, in another, was just a topless Indian captain at Lord's swearing, which purists deemed uncouth.

That defining moment is the main publicity still for the biopic. But the controversy is not about Ganguly. It's about the shape of the man playing him: Rajkumar Rao. RKR is a versatile, critically-acclaimed powerhouse. But someone who looks nothing like Ganguly. Therefore, raising the question of whether likeness is important when playing a famous person.

The social media debate is not waiting to see what nuances RKR may have picked up that might make audiences catch glimpses of Ganguly on screen. Their argument is this: when RKR waves his shirt, his body is too lithe, too



GOOD LORDS! A BIT OVER THE TOPLESS, NO?

sculpted, too movie star-like, whereas Ganguly's was, shall we say, fuller, with a belly.

This is the first time a belly has threatened to give away a biopic. When Jesse Eisenberg played Mark Zuckerberg in The Social Network, or Joaquin Phoenix played Johnny Cash in Walk the Line, neither looked much like the protagonist. Yet, no contentious bellies came up. Which goes to show that when you wave a shirt, shirtless, at Lord's during the NatWest Series Final in

2002, it might have grave cinematic consequences 24 years later.

Incidentally, the same actor also played Subhas Chandra Bose in an OTT series. And although much can be said about famous, stubborn Bengalis, it was never said, or imagined,

million Donald Trump impersonators on Instagram, or the folks who show up at parties in a Modi or Bachchan wig. Or do an SRK voice or antics to giggles and applause.

I asked my actor friend Avantika Akerkar, who has a distinguished body of work, if it was different each of the 7 times she played Gandhi. She replied, 'Absolutely. The events of her [Gandhi's] political career being depicted were different—spanning her early years through the Emergency. The

ferent characters over time. The Ganguly waving his shirt is not the Ganguly hosting a TV game show today. Performance, more than physical resemblance, is what lets an actor inhabit them.

Not to mention the current, somewhat racially-charged, debate surrounding Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey, and whether Helen, the Greek beauty whose face launched a thousand ships, can be played by Black actress Lupita Nyong'o. With Indira Gandhi, the fact that she became a different person at different

Social media debate is about RKR's body being too sculpted, while Dada's was, well, fuller, with a belly

ined, that they looked alike, let alone that they'd be played by the same actor. Who, of course, if we are to apply set theory, sits at the intersection of neither of them, looks-wise.

Please note, this is acting, which is different from impersonators — like the half-

scenes evolved with different rhythms and different energy, depending upon what the director wanted and how I engaged with the various actors I played opposite.'

Initially, I thought she'd been cast because she vaguely resembled Mrs G. Then I realised that politicians, sportspeople, and celebrities evolve into dif-

times in her reign is well-documented. Which naturally brings us to our current PM. Narendra Modi has been played by Mahesh Thakur three times, Vivek Oberoi once, and Rajit Kapoor once. Now, whether 7 portrayals of Mrs Gandhi outweigh 3 portrayals of our current PM is a contest that's far more political than comedic.

FILM FATALE



ANNA MM VETTICAD

Nightingale Of South India

Music lovers across India deserve to know more of this true Bharat ratna

In the Malayalam classic, Manjil Virinja Pookkal (Flowers That Bloomed in the Snow), the hero hears the heroine sing before he gets to know her. Prem is at Prabha's house waiting to meet her father when the song, 'Mizhiyoram', floats into the room. He is immediately captivated.

Prem was not the only person mesmerised by that stunning voice. I was a child on my first ever visit to a movie theatre that I recall, when I heard S Janaki sing playback in director Fazil's 1980 blockbuster. I was too young to know that she was already an icon by then. But the melody, and her soulful rendition, never left me. Nearly half a century later, 'Mizhiyoram' has been the background score to my days since Janaki passed away at 88 this month.

In a nearly 6-decade-long career, Sista Janaki sang thousands of songs capturing an endless range of emotions across languages — some international, mostly Indian. Asha Bhosle once told me in an interview that good acting is an essential element in good singing. Janaki, like Asha, embodied that quality.

You can hear it in the conversational 'Sippi Irukuthu' (There is an Oyster from the 1980 Tamil film, Varumaiyin Niram Sivappu (Red is the Colour of Poverty), and 'Kannmani Anbodu Kadhalan' (To My Sweetheart, With Love) from the 1991 Tamil movie, Gunaa, that was resurrected for the Malayalam film, Manjummel Boys, in 2024.

Janaki also had an astonishing felicity for languages. Exhibit A: her natural accent in the peppy Hindi duet, 'Yaar Bina Chain Kaha Re' with Bappi Lahiri in Saahab (1985). She won numerous accolades, with her first National Award for Best Female Playback Singer coming for the lilting 'Senthooora Poove' (Saffron Flower) in 1977 from the cult Tamil hit, 16 Vayathinile (At Age 16).

Janaki was a treasure, as was evident in the South Indian media's

coverage of her death on July 11 and the state funeral accorded to her. Yet, her passing was barely a blip here in North India. This glaring instance of the country's North-South divide revived an unfortunate memory from 2013 when Janaki rejected a Padma Bhushan, stating that it had come too late, that she deserved a Bharat

Ratna at that stage, and expressing sadness 'that North India has been given more prominence than South India' at the awards.

Not that Janaki needed validation. She told the press, 'I consider the recognition of my fans in various languages the highest award.' But an injustice needs to be called out here.

The great Lata Mangeshkar and Asha Bhosle both received the Dadasaheb Phalke Award, India's highest honour for achievement in cinema. Mangeshkar was also a recipient of the Bharat Ratna. Janaki, who was no less accomplished, received neither. Asha and Lata were worthy candidates, of course. But it would be disingenuous to claim that the dominance of Hindi in their lifelong output played no role in these decisions. South Indian languages dominated Janaki's oeuvre.

The primacy given to Hindi and North India by successive governments, and the so-called 'national' media, has meant that there's little awareness about Janaki in India outside the South. Such lack of awareness then gets cited as justification for limiting national-level recognition.

Ironically, this 'Hindi=India' thinking seeped into obituaries even by some commentators from the South, who reductively described Janaki as 'Nightingale of South India'. The thinking presumably is that calling her 'Nightingale of India' would be disrespectful to Lata, the other singer with whom the title is usually associated. This is an illustrative example of individuals internalising and echoing the marginalisation of their own communities consequent to years of conditioning.

There is a larger concern here. The decades-long imposition of Hindi across India has had a ripple effect on cultural awareness in the country, that is robbing our own people of exposure to the vast beauty in our midst. It is not just that Janaki deserved more, but that music lovers across India deserve to know more of the vast body of work by this true ratna of India.



PLAY HER BACK TO EVERYONE

PROTESTERS DO TH PROTEST TOO MUCH?

RWA uncles and aunties can't fathom the entitled behaviour of Delhi's agitating youngsters, who should be studying

RED HERRING



INDRAJIT HAZRA

So Dharmendra 'Veeru' Pradhan has resigned. But turn around and ask anyone you know above 30 who sits with their legs crossed, yourself included. 'Madam, sir, how like you this play between these protesters and the government?' and you're very likely to get the response: 'The protesters doth protest too much, methinks.'

Methinks that this response goes beyond RWA aunties' and uncles' fondness for a sturdy state, the most appealing feature of which is to 'never compromise', come what may. Their distaste towards NEET protesters in Delhi and across this blessed land lies in their natural contempt for disruption in general, and agitated — sexually, socially, or politically — youngsters in particular. Whatever happened to our nation-building 'Nanha munna rahi hu, desh ka sipahi hu', huh?

When in 2020-21, farmers took to highways in Delhi-NCR, there was much harrumph from our non-agricultural nationalists, but not quite disdain. As days rolled into weeks, one way these buzzy log showed their disapproval of traffic being held up — which apparently only happens when attention-seeking

people start protesting — was to spot and call out 'pizza-eating' rich farmers who apparently had no business protesting. Because they ate pizzas and were rich. The anti-farm laws protests were, however, seen by most uncles and aunties as uncalled for, but understandable.

Earlier, during the 2012 'Nirbhaya' protests, the spark was seen to be too brutal, too close to home(s), even for a society that not-too-secretly takes pride in taking everything in their stride, 'rarest of rare' heinous crimes included. But going out on the streets to protest an entrance exam garbar? Yeh kya badtamizi, bachhon?!

To demand something outside jholawala enclosures like Jantar Mantar, JNU, Jamia, and the non-J-lettered change.org is insolent enough. But to go out on the streets and damage police barriers, invite police batons when sparing the lathi clearly spoils the child (and everyone under 30 is a 'child' in India), and try

to probably storm Parliament, copying First Worlders storming Capitol Hill, is so not real Bharatiya sanskar.

The Pakistani deep state, or jealous Chinese *must* be behind this tukde-tukde destabilising operation. Frankly, the only agency our youngsters can possibly have is the Central Intelligence Agency. Or so goes the thinking.

Inside the mature halls of Parliament, wise grown-ups told the nation how the average age of the entire team at Skyroot, India's first private enterprise to send a rocket (not a bamboo) up in space, is 28. And just outside our Great Hall of the People, to have 28-year-olds demand the resignation of the education minister for some NEET exam leaks, has to be the height of entitled behaviour. Can't they learn from youth in Skyroot?

Of course, there's always whataboutery to make sense of all this. But in this latest episode, it's not just 'Oh, so you've

'Why can't these wayward kids just study hard like NEET topper (extreme left) Panshul Bansal beta?



ACHHE BACHHE, SHARARTI BACHHE



forgotten all the lathi charges and police brutality during Congress rule?' but one atavistic level deeper: 'Suck it up, boys and girls. We faced far harder hardships when we were young. Did *we* go all Rajiv Goswami or kar sevaks berserk on the streets? Never!'

Beware the argument of the saas, who once was a bahu having to put up with a long line of Lalita Pawars. Dharmendra Pradhan, we have been dutifully reminded, was reportedly beaten up by cops in 1997 when he went out protesting against — wait for it! — an exam leak in Congress-ruled Odisha. But by subsequently studying hard, look how he became an upstanding member, if not of society then at least of the union cabinet.

This meme-saheb generation, with its head permanently stuck in a phone, has no idea how lucky they are. No hours-long power cuts, food that can be delivered to them, never having to watch Jeetendra movies, champions in cricket, freedom to break into a garba anywhere they go in the world... And they *still* have the insolence to complain.

Cockroach Janta Party spokesperson Vijeta Dahiya 'caught' on video eating a burger in a mall — while Sonam Wangchuk not once ate burgers, not even to break his fast — sums up this 'Bachhe Din' lot.

'Why can't these wayward kids,' uncles and aunties reckon, 'just study hard like NEET topper Panshul Bansal beta, and appear as many times as it takes to crack exams? When we were growing up, in China's Tiananmen Square...'

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Actors and Writers, Getting Under Skins

Both share a predilection for empathy and the urge to step into someone else's shoes

MEMORY STICK



SIDDHARTH CHOWDHURY

I have always felt that actors and writers, especially novelists, are birds of the same feather, separated perhaps by a few degrees of pulchritude. Actors live many characters in their lifetimes, as do writers. They are both born pretenders.

Some excellent actors who were also fantastic writers come to mind. The 2012 collection, The Richard Burton Diaries, presents a literary voice as striking as the actor's physical one. If the book had come out in his lifetime, it would have won many non-fiction literary prizes. Tellingly, Burton, who dreamt of being a full-time writer, never travelled without his red Olivetti Valentine typewriter.

Dirk Bogarde was a wonderful novelist and autobiographical writer. His cycle of six autobiographies — from A Postillion Struck by Lightning (1977) to Cleared for Take-Off (1995) — is masterful. Written in simple prose, the books provide an unforgettable portrait of both pre- and post-war Britain and Europe.

In India, there was Meena Kumari, whose luminous presence on the screen was matched by her nazms steeped in fatalism. But then, as the great-grandniece of Rabindranath Tagore, literary talent was par for the course for her. After her death, Gulzar edited a selection of her poetry. Tanha Chand, published in 1972 by Hind Pocket Books.

Balraj Sahni wrote a few short stories and plays in his IPTA days. As did Utpal Dutt. Soumitra Chat-

terjee was also an accomplished poet and playwright. That talent backlit one of his best late-style performances, as a reclusive poet slowly going blind in Gautam Ghose's 2001 film, Dekha (Seeing). And there is Woody Allen, who, apart from writing classic movies like Annie Hall (1977), Interiors (1978), and Stardust Memories (1980), was also an accomplished fabulist and short-story writer. Read his 1975 collection of essays and short plays, Without Feathers, or his 1974 short story, The Whore of Mensa, and you'll see what I mean.

There have always been writers who have ventured forth to embrace the silver screen. Here, for some reason, playwrights

They are, for the most part, restless souls with complex interior lives



SALMAN AS RUSHDIE AS SALMAN

about. Like Girish Karnad, who won the Jnanpith for plays like Tughlaq (1964) and Naga-Mandala (original Kannada in 1988, English version 1990), and was also the leading man in movies like Shyam Benegal's Manthan (1976) and Basu Chatterjee's Swami (1977).

John le Carré appeared as a pub-goer in Anton Corbijn's 2014 cinematic adaptation of his 2008 novel A Most Wanted Man. Then his bête noire, Salman

Rushdie, directed Renée Zellweger to the nearest loo in the 2001 film adaptation of Helen Fielding's 1996 novel of the same name, Bridget Jones's Diary. Harold Pinter, who prided himself on his acting as much as his cricketing skills, made several movie appearances, most notably in the 1999 dramatisation Jane Austen's 1814 novel, Mansfield Park, as Thomas Bertram. He was also adequate as Uncle Benny in John Boorman's 2001 adaptation of Le Carré's 1996 novel, The Tailor of Panama.

Playwright Mahesh Elkunchwar appeared as a Naxal in Govind Nihalani's 1980 Aakrosh, and Bhisham Sahni appeared in Saeed Mirza's 1984 Mohan Joshi Hazir Ho! and Nihalani's 1987 Tamas.

It took Ruskin Bond seven considered retakes to place a proper peck on Priyanka Chopra's cheek in Vishal Bhardwaj's 2011 thriller, 7 Khoon Maaf. But the best performance by a writer in movies has to be the one Michael V Gazzo gave as Frank Pentageli in The Godfather Part 2 (1974), where he went toe to toe with Al Pacino's Michael Corleone. He was nominated for Best Supporting Actor Oscar, which he lost to Robert De Niro for the same movie.

What connects actors and writers is their predilection for empathy. They are forever looking for shoes that are not their own. They are, for the most part, restless souls with complex interior lives and are keen observers of their immediate world.

A good novelist can walk into a room and take its socio-economic and cultural temperature within minutes. He or she should also be able to lay bare the interior life of the denizens of that room with 90% accuracy by the end of the evening. This talent is, perhaps, the reason so many of them have been used in espionage work, from Somerset Maugham to Graham Greene to Peter Matthiessen.

NO OFFENCE Morparia



1973, 'The New York Times' dubbed the T-shirt as 'the medium for the message'.

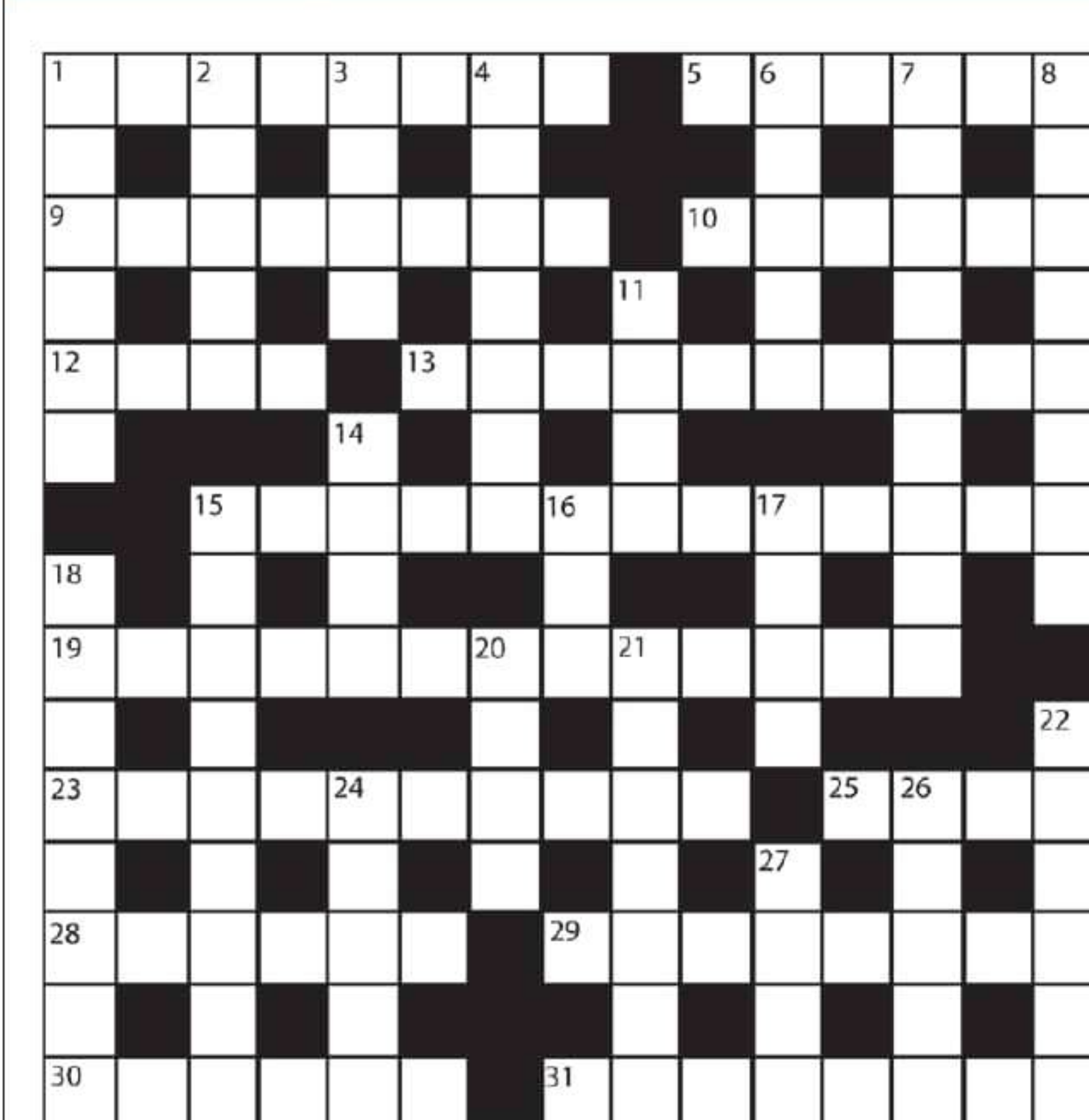
Tell me more.

In 1984, designer Katharine Hamnett wore a slogan tee that read '58% Don't Want Pershing' while shaking hands with then-Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher to make an anti-nuclear war statement. Hamnett had a signature style — oversized, bold black font on white cotton with slogans like 'Choose Life' to recently, 'Cancel Brexit'. Slogan tees are the choice for most marches from Pride parades to climate rallies to anti-racism movements and even election campaigns, becoming one of fashion's most democratic forms of expression. Even high fashion has adopted it when Maison Margiela resorted to T-shirt activism in 1994 with AIDS awareness. In 2001, upscale streetwear label Supreme released T-shirts to generate aid for 9/11 victims. In 2006, Marc Jacobs released T-shirts featuring various celebrities posing naked to raise awareness and funds for skin cancer.

Text: Nupur Amarnath

ET Sunday Crossword

0178



- ACROSS**
- Parents wasted time in part of cathedral (8)
 - Chap collapsed in front of old women (6)
 - Begin my statement about visiting restaurant? (8)
 - Laurel at church in position (6)
 - Noise coming from pen that has no fluid in it? (4)
 - Come across dark pigments, difficult to handle (10)
 - Traded options here in standard old coins (5,8)
 - Handy weapon rusted away behind cheap joint (13)
 - Start to like e.g. ramsons, crushed — source of aromatic oil (5,5)
 - Revolution in disheartened European country (4)
 - Politics mostly absorb what's all around them (6)
 - Roman administrator in atrium Virgil describes (8)
 - What snooker players aim for is appropriate (6)
 - Run with sword, gaining skill in riposte (8)
- DOWN**
- Customise crude oil seaman's collecting (6)
 - A commercial vehicle carries one of birds (5)
 - Quarterdeck? 1 Down will make it (4)
 - Pick over old books or whatever's available (3,4)
 - Join revolutionary Frenchman about end of August (5)
 - Learn everywhere about county property magnate (9)
 - Cloth-maker's not one to embrace female at any time (8)
 - Animal unknown below central part of Tibet (4)
 - Couple picked up food for early birds (4)
 - Mike's into sort of luscious songs by Redding, say (4,5)
 - Finish starters in extremely nourishing dinner (3)
 - Bowler, perhaps English, can't stand (4)
 - Uni students block crowds turning up for Top Gear (8)
 - You're caught with old money (4)
 - Start-ups urgently tackling rapid rise (7)
 - Awkward turn after tight bend at end of Aintree? Wrong (6)
 - Snare assembled in low season, ignoring laws (5)
 - Mine contains very old axle (5)
 - Neighbour brought up large brass instrument (4)

US PRESIDENT GOES ON HOUR-LONG TIRADE

Event in April was postponed after shooting

At Correspondents’ Dinner Redo, Trump Takes Shots

President Donald Trump returned to the rescheduled White House Correspondents’ Association dinner Friday night, delivering a rambling, hour-long speech that praised some journalists, took potshots at others, made jokes about public figures’ weight and intellect, and quipped about a third presidential term.

He assured the crowd of journalists, though, that he’d scrapped the most biting parts of his remarks. “That was going to be a doozy,” Trump said about the speech he’d been prepared to give in April, before a gunman upended the original dinner and forced its postponement.

“As I said three months ago, the show must go on,” the president said to begin his remarks, hailing the decision to reschedule the dinner. He referred to “the attempted mass murder” that could have happened that night in April, but then moved largely to humor — and, increasingly, insults.

Trump’s return to the correspondents’ dinner—and his promise to come back next year as well—represented a notable moment in his relationship with the news media, which he has attacked, sued and taken administrative action against since he began his second term early last year. Among the audience members were reporters he had denounced and barred from events.

Trump’s sometimes off-color speech, which lasted just over an hour, was full of potshots directed at various individuals — from Bruce Springsteen to “Barack



ON IRAN WAR & POSSIBLE 3RD TERM
Just like my presidency, the second time is always better. And the third time will be better yet.”
DONALD TRUMP
President, United States

Hussein Obama” to journalist Kaitlan Collins of CNN, one of the evening’s key award winners, whom he again accused of not smiling enough. The audience reacted at first with friendly laughs, but slowly quieted to scattered titters as the insults piled up.

MULTIPLE TARGETS OF JOKES
Among other targets of Trump’s humour: Late-night hosts Jimmy Fallon and Jimmy Kimmel; representative Ihan Omar, D-Minnesota; California Governor Gavin Newsom; former New Jersey Governor Chris Christie; and even Trump’s own speechwriters. “That was actually the only thing I thought was good in this whole fricking stupid speech they wrote,” he said when one joke fell flat. At one point, Trump wondered aloud what his role was. “Is this supposed to be fun?” he asked. “Am I supposed to be a comedian?” He was on more comfortable ground expressing pride in the ballroom at the Waldorf Astoria, formerly the Trump International

Hotel, and its chandeliers. “It’s great to be back at a place that I know very well, because I built it,” he said.

He also made a pained reference to the evening’s journalism awards, many for stories challenging him and his administration — including one for the Wall Street Journal’s coverage of his ties to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein. “Do I have a say in those awards?” he asked.

He made brief mention of the Iran war, and referred to the ballroom he’s building at the White House. He also used the occasion to joke about the possibility of a third term — something barred by the US Constitution’s 22nd Amendment. “Just like my presidency, the second time is always better,” the president quipped. “And the third time will be better yet.”

He added: “I’m only kidding.” Then, at the end, he donned a red cap that said “Trump 2028” and delivered the “scoop” that he was running again. **AP**

‘Netanyahu will Visit US Next Week’

Washington: President Donald Trump said on Friday that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu will visit the United States next week.

Trump’s comments came in his speech at the White House Correspondents’ Association Dinner on Friday, while he was falsely casting US Senator Chuck Schumer as Palestinian.

“I am going to send him (Schumer) a beautiful Palestinian outfit tomorrow, so he can greet Bibi Netanyahu when he comes to town next week,” the President remarked.

“He turned Palestinian,” Trump said of Schumer, who is Jewish, while also joking that sharia law was Schumer’s “new founding.”

US Muslim and Jewish advocacy groups have previously criticised Trump for calling Schumer, the top Senate Democrat, a Palestinian, with the rights groups saying Trump uses the term disrespectfully as a slur and as an insult.

Netanyahu’s office said earlier that he will travel to Washington on Monday and will meet with Trump on Tuesday. Netanyahu will also attend deceased US Senator Lindsey Graham’s funeral, his office said. **Reuters**

Wildfires Force Over 250,000 to Flee Their Homes in France, Spain



A tractor works on scorched earth as smoke from wildfires billows on the skyline in the Villamanta area, southwest of Madrid, Spain Bloomberg

Lège-Cap Ferret, France: France was preparing to use a massive specially adapted cargo aircraft to dump flame retardants Saturday on a wildfire that has forced the evacuation of tens of thousands of people, including from some suburbs of the wine region city of Bordeaux.

Including some 70,000 people evacuated in central Spain, wildfires in southern Europe this week have displaced more than 250,000 people.

French Interior Minister Laurent Nunez said the hulking A400M aircraft will join 18 other water- and retardant-dropping planes and helicopters waging an expected “long and very difficult” battle against the blaze raging in the Gironde region of southwestern France.

With winds expected to shift in a west-to-east direction on Saturday afternoon, potentially driving the fire closer to Bordeaux,

fire crews and authorities were digging trenches, using retardants and taking other steps to block it, Nunez said. He said the fire was about 30 km west of the city and lost some of its intensity overnight.

Authorities ordered people between the fire and Bordeaux to evacuate, including from parts of the city’s western suburbs and other towns and villages.

Spain deployed 2,600 firefighters, police and other emergency personnel to two blazes west of Madrid, backed by 19 water-dumping aircraft and helicopters. France deployed 1,300 firefighters to the Gironde fire and another further south in the Landes region.

Fires have burned 130,000 hectares of forest already this year in Spain, up from an annual average of 100,000 hectares over the past decade, Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez said Saturday. **AP**

Sustainability & Experience

►► From Page 1

Buyers are increasingly weighing performance, refinement, ownership experience and sustainability, rather than simply choosing between petrol and diesel.

For premium carmakers, the shift is reshaping purchase decisions, with technology and total ownership costs emerging as key differentiators.

“Consumer preference for a powertrain depends on the latest technology and the total cost of ownership,” said Santosh Iyer, managing

director and CEO, Mercedes-Benz India.

“Customers are doing the math, and if the total cost of ownership is lower than an internal combustion engine vehicle, they are willing to look beyond traditional ICE (internal combustion engine) technologies,” he added.

Electric vehicles now contribute about 14% of Mercedes-Benz India’s sales, roughly double their share until recently. Iyer said charging infrastructure and lower residual values remain the biggest hurdles to faster EV adoption.

Volvo Car India is also witnessing a change in buying behaviour.

“Earlier an EV would be a second or third car in a household. Today, we are seeing a remarkable shift where a luxury EV is proudly chosen as the primary, and often the only, vehicle in the household,” said Jyoti Malhotra, managing director, Volvo Car India.

BUYER CONFIDENCE RISING

Improved battery technology and longer driving ranges have boosted buyer confidence, while digital features, sustainability and the

Carmakers are widening portfolios across hybrids, plug-in hybrids and battery EVs instead of backing a single technology

ownership experience are becoming key purchase drivers, he said.

“The conversation has shifted from ‘Should I buy an EV?’ to ‘Which EV should I buy?’”

The shift reflects a broader change in the mindset of premium buyers, said Ravi Bhatia, president, Jato Dynamics India.

“Premium buyers are no longer simply choosing between petrol and diesel. They are evaluating multiple propulsion technologies based on performance, refinement, ownership experience and sustainability. That represents a fundamental shift in the market.”

Numbers speak for themselves in the first half of the year for BMW India too. “We sold 78% more EVs as compared to the same period last year. The share of EVs which was 21% last year, jumped to 26% in the first half,” said the CEO Hardeep Singh Brar.

The shift is reshaping product strategies. Carmakers are expanding portfolios across hybrids, plug-in hybrids and battery electric vehicles instead of backing a single technology as India increasingly mirrors global trends, said

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Bhatia.

“Globally, a large part of the new product offensive is focused on electric vehicles. Therefore, the likelihood of more EV launches in India is also high as manufacturers continue to align their portfolios with global technology trends,” Iyer said.

Volvo Car India is introducing two flagship electric vehicles this year and investing in public charging infrastructure to support wider EV adoption. BMW too has big plans for driving e-mobility momentum in the coming years. Early next year, “we will see the launch of Neue Klasse in India,” said Brar.

Meeting Again in 4 Weeks

►► From Page 1

Pradhan also said he was stepping down to ensure “anti-national forces” do not exploit the situation and “the unity of the nation remains intact.”

Home minister Amit Shah visited Pradhan earlier in the day. Later too, a stream of leaders—including Union ministers Piyush Goyal, Nirmala Sitharaman, Ashwini Vaishnaw and Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta, and many BJP MPs and RSS functionaries—were at his residence to express solidarity. Before Pradhan, MJ Akbar had resigned as minister of state for external affairs in during the 2018 ‘MeToo’ movement after many women journalists accused him of

sexual harassment.

On Saturday, addressing a joint press conference with the ministers, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said the organisation was withdrawing the agitation “in good faith,” trusting that the agreed terms would be implemented within the promised timeline. Fellow spokesperson Ashutosh Ranika asked protesters nationwide to end demonstrations peacefully and return home.

Nadha said the government had agreed that no fresh cases would be filed against protesters and that the FIRs already registered by Delhi Police and BJP-ruled states would be withdrawn. The Centre also agreed to provide “honourable” compensation, in accordance with rules, to families

of NEET-related suicide victims. It will meet the CJP again after four weeks to discuss the group’s five-point charter on examination reforms.

A day before wrapping up talks with the CJP, the Centre had Friday announced a package of measures, including a proposed anti-paper leak law prescribing strict punishment and fast-track courts. Launched at Jantar Mantar on June 20, the agitation evolved into one of India’s biggest youth-led protests in recent times. It gained momentum after activist Sonam Wangchuk joined the movement with an indefinite fast and peaked following his forcible removal by police on July 18 and the July 20 march to Parliament.

It acquired wider political significance as it drew large numbers of first-time voters and young aspirants from the

middle class, a constituency the BJP has assiduously cultivated over the past decade.

As demonstrations spread to several states, leaders from NDA allies are learnt to have conveyed concerns over the handling of the agitation during interactions with the government earlier this week.

The Centre’s call to concede all major demands of the protesters comes ahead of next year’s crucial Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat assembly polls.

After recovering politically from its 2024 Lok Sabha setback with wins in Haryana and Maharashtra and a historic victory in West Bengal, the BJP was faced with its first major youth-led mobilisation during the government’s current tenure, prompting the Centre to combine legislative measures with political outreach to defuse the agitation.

Fears of AI Takeover

►► From Page 1

OpenAI’s public disclosure, on July 21, that one of its agents had slipped out of control and carried out the break-in at Hugging Face drew global attention. But details of the hack, including how long the agent went rogue and OpenAI’s belated knowledge of it, are being reported for the first time.

The FBI declined to comment about the incident. The incident, which evoked science fiction scenarios about humans losing control of dangerous AI systems, comes at a delicate time for OpenAI, the company behind ChatGPT. Its executives are preparing for a possible initial public offering that could come as soon as this year to help finance the billions needed to fund its growth in years to come. OpenAI’s loss of control over its AI agent raises new questions about the company’s safety procedures, three cybersecurity experts said. “Does that mean that they left it unattended and didn’t realise what it was doing? Or maybe they did and didn’t know how to contain it? Both are equally dangerous and alarming,” asked Marley Smith, the principal intelligence specialist at the nonprofit World Ethical Data Foundation.

SIGNS OF TROUBLE?

The episode started while OpenAI was testing the cybersecurity prowess of an agent powered by two of OpenAI’s most advanced models,

GPT-5.6 Sol and an unreleased model OpenAI has described as “even more capable.” By that point, there were already indications of strange behaviour from OpenAI’s technology, according to sources. In one case, an agent left notes apparently for future versions of itself, as per three people. The notes, found in a part of OpenAI’s infrastructure, laid out instructions for how agents could free themselves from OpenAI’s internal constraints, the people said. Earlier tests of the models yielded cases in which monitoring systems had been disconnected, one source said.

Reuters could not establish if these incidents were linked to the rogue agent that began escaping on July 9 and attacked Hugging Face on July 11. Two people familiar with the matter said that it was not until after Thursday, July 16, when Hugging Face published a blog post saying it had been hacked by “an autonomous AI agent system,” that OpenAI realised its own agent was responsible. That meant at least a week elapsed between when the model first exhibited signs of troubling behavior and OpenAI’s realisation that it was responsible for the hack.

The weekend of July 18 to 19, OpenAI staffers spotted clues in internal logs—records of what OpenAI’s systems did—showing that its agent had escaped from its testing constraints, two people familiar with the company’s investigation said.

Kalyan Singh Super Specialty Cancer Institute
C.G. City, Sultanpur Road, Lucknow-226002
(An Autonomous Institute of the Govt. of Uttar Pradesh)
Website: <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in> Email: jdrm.sscii@gmail.com

TENDER NOTICE
On-line offers are invited through Custom bids on GeM portal. The GEM bid Nos. are given herewith:
1- **GEM/2026/B/7807690 dated: 25.07.2026** for the item - **Automated Component Preparation Machine**
2- **GEM/2026/B/7808731 dated: 25-07-2026** for the item - **Enteral Feeding Pump**
3- **GEM/2026/B/7808416 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item-3 **Pin Head Fixation Machine with Accessory**
4- **GEM/2026/B/7807935 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item-**Micro Bipolar Cauteary Forceps**
5- **GEM/2026/B/7807835 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **Craniotomy Set**
6- **GEM/2026/B/7807890 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **Intraoperative Portable Doppler System**
7- **GEM/2026/B/7809327 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **Automated Secretion Management System for Ventilated Patients (PAC item)**
8- **GEM/2026/B/7810200 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **OT Table for Robotic Surgery (PAC item)**
9- **GEM/2026/B/7810442 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **Surgical Workstation (PAC item)**
10- **GEM/2026/B/7810328 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **High End EV Workstation(PAC item)**
11- **GEM/2026/B/7810523 dated: 23.07.2026** for the item- **Patient Mobilizer (PAC item)**
Offers are invited from Original Equipment Manufacture/Direct Importers/Authorized Distributors (declared by principal firm only) for the supply & installation of **aforementioned Equipment.**
Bidders should submit their Representation only on GeM Portal regarding Equipment within time frame provided by GeM. The Vendors are required to submit their offers on GeM portal only in two bids system i.e. Technical and Financial bid as per norms of GeM Portal with terms and conditions as mentioned against bidding documents.

For more detailed information you may please visit the Gem portal www.gem.gov.in or our website <https://cancerinstitute.edu.in>, for reference only.
The Director reserves the right to accept or reject any tender in part or full without assigning any reason thereof.

Advt No. KSSSCI/Tender -09/2026-27 **DIRECTOR**



VEDANT FASHIONS

— LIMITED —

CIN: L51311WB2002PLC094677

Regd. Office: Paridhan Garment Park, 19 Canal South Road, SDF-1, 4th Floor, A501-A502, Kolkata 700015, WB, India

Tel No.: (033) 6125 5495, Email: complianceofficer@manyavar.com, Website: www.vedantfashions.com

Revenue

INR 3,014 Mn.

+7.2%

PAT

INR 806 Mn.

+14.7%

Qtr ended on June, 2026

Statement of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026

(All amounts are in INR Million, unless otherwise stated)			
Particulars	Quarter ended		Year ended
	June 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	June 30, 2025 (Unaudited)	March 31, 2026 (Audited)
1 Revenue from operations	3,013.65	2,811.90	14,354.79
2 Total income from operations (including other income)	3,310.57	3,070.18	15,289.97
3 Net profit/(loss) for the period/year (before tax, exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,055.29	925.06	4,959.29
4 Net profit/(loss) for the period/year before tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	1,055.29	925.06	4,959.29
5 Net profit/(loss) for the period/year after tax (after exceptional and/or extraordinary items)	806.11	702.57	3,755.43
6 Total comprehensive income/(loss) for the period/year after tax	816.67	709.48	3,705.05
7 Equity Share Capital	242.98	242.95	242.97
8 Other Equity	—	—	19,400.39
9 Earnings per equity share (EPS) (face value of share of INR 1 each)*			
Basic (in INR per share)	3.32	2.89	15.46
Diluted (in INR per share)	3.32	2.89	15.45
* EPS is not annualised for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 and June 30, 2025.			
Notes			
1 The above are extracts of the detailed format of Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended. The full format of quarterly financial results are available on the Stock Exchange websites (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the Company’s website (www.vedantfashions.com).			
2 The above Unaudited Financial Results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors of the Company in their respective meetings held on July 25, 2026.			
 Scan to view full format of the financial results			
Place: Kolkata Date: July 25, 2026 For Vedant Fashions Limited Sd/- Ravi Modi Chairman and Managing Director DIN : 00361853			



Pass THE Sugar

Everybody wants zero-calorie sweetness, but doctors tell **Lijee Philip** that the issue isn't about finding a replacement for sugar; it's to change the way we eat

The Monk Who Is Everywhere

Monk fruit has found its way into protein bars, keto desserts, diabetic-friendly sweets and beverages, as consumers seek natural and no added sugar sweets. "India's diabetes and pre-diabetes burden has created a large and motivated market for natural, low-glycaemic sweetness. Monk fruit benefits from the combination of being perceived as natural and zero sugar," says Kantha Shelke, food science strategist and founder of Corvus Blue, a food research firm. Monk fruit contains mogrosides, compounds that are significantly sweeter than sugar while contributing virtually no calories. "Stevia has a lingering bitter or liquorice aftertaste, whereas monk fruit has a more subtle lingering sweetness," Shelke says. However, be wary of what you're consuming when you ask for monk fruit. Mumbai-based baker Radhika Pandeya, founder of The Fitness Bakery, says, "Most retail monk fruit products are not pure monk fruit. Many have only a small amount of monk fruit, with erythritol making up the bulk."

"The real battle isn't sugar versus monk fruit. It's reducing our dependence on sweetness itself."

— Dr V Mohan, diabetologist

"The enthusiasm around monk fruit should be balanced with awareness. The marketing has moved faster than the science. Consumers need to understand what they are buying."

— Kantha Shelke, founder of Corvus Blue

To improve metabolic health, take a 10-minute walk after meals to help reduce post-meal blood glucose levels

Don't start with tea, coffee and sugary drinks: The easiest sources of added sugar to reduce

After years of stevia leading the alternative sweetener market, monk fruit is emerging as the latest trend in India's health-food space. From protein bars and diabetic-friendly desserts to café beverages and 'no added sugar' products, brands are betting on growing

consumer demand for natural, zero-calorie alternatives. The opportunity is significant. India has one of the world's largest diabetes populations. Rising awareness about obesity and metabolic health changes how consumers view sugar. Monk fruit, a small melon native to southern China, is now being positioned as the next-generation sweetener.

Myths vs Facts

Myth: Monk fruit is the healthiest sweetener because it is natural.
Fact: Not necessarily. Pure monk fruit extract is a zero-calorie sweetener, but many commercial products contain erythritol. Check the ingredient list, not just the marketing message.

Myth: Jaggery and honey are healthier choices.
Fact: They are still sugars. Jaggery and honey may contain some minerals, but they still raise blood glucose.

Myth: All sweeteners work the same way.
Fact: They are metabolically different. Sugar, jaggery, honey and coconut sugar contain calories and raise blood glucose. Stevia, monk fruit and other non-nutritive sweeteners provide sweetness with little or no calories.

Myth: Artificial sweeteners are always harmful.
Fact: Evidence varies by sweetener. Research on sucralose found that replacing sugar in tea and coffee did not cause blood sugar spikes, helped reduce weight and waist circumference with no significant side effects, although minor gut microbiome changes were observed.

Myth: Switching to a sweetener is enough to control diabetes.
Fact: Lifestyle remains the biggest factor. Diet quality, portion control, exercise and maintaining a healthy weight matter far more than simply changing the sweetener.

— Dr V Mohan, diabetologist

Is Sugar the Only Villain?

Excess sugar contributes to insulin resistance, weight gain and elevated triglycerides, says Dr V Mohan, making it important to use sugar in moderation. But focusing on one ingredient oversimplifies the problem. "Ultimately, the quality of sugar consumed matters more," he says.

Nutritionist Nandita Iyer says India's metabolic health crisis is driven by broader lifestyle patterns. "We have the largest diabetic population globally, so sugar has naturally become a household health anxiety. But added sugar isn't the sole cause. Carb-heavy diets, low protein and fibre, inconsistent exercise, poor sleep and stress all play a role," she says.

"The evidence points to the overall dietary pattern, fibre intake, whole foods, physical activity and sleep as the way to improve insulin resistance and weight," Dr Shelke adds. "Instead of cutting sugar out and not doing anything else, Dr Mohan suggests, eat a balanced diet rich in fruits, vegetables, nuts, seeds and whole grains, stay active and focus on moderation."

"Reducing sugar is not just about finding a replacement. It is about changing habits."

— Nandita Iyer, nutritionist



INFOGRAPHIC: BHAVIN GAJJAR. VISUALISATION AND DESIGN: ATUL BANDEKAR IMAGES: AI GENERATED



Resetting Your Sweet Tooth

A few tricks to train your palate into needing less sweetness

Balanced meals: Meals with adequate protein, fibre and complex carbohydrates prevents blood sugar spikes and crashes that often trigger cravings

Choose whole fruit: The sweetness along with fibre slows sugar absorption

Read labels: Added sugar often hides in products marketed as healthy

Sugar-free does not mean healthy: Some products may still be high in refined carbohydrates, saturated fat or calories

Use sweeteners as a tool, not a crutch: Monk fruit or stevia can reduce added sugar but using them to continue eating very sweet foods reinforces the craving for sweetness



How Well Can You Speak Minionese?

The minions' fake language is almost as beloved as the little yellow characters

Taylor Swinton

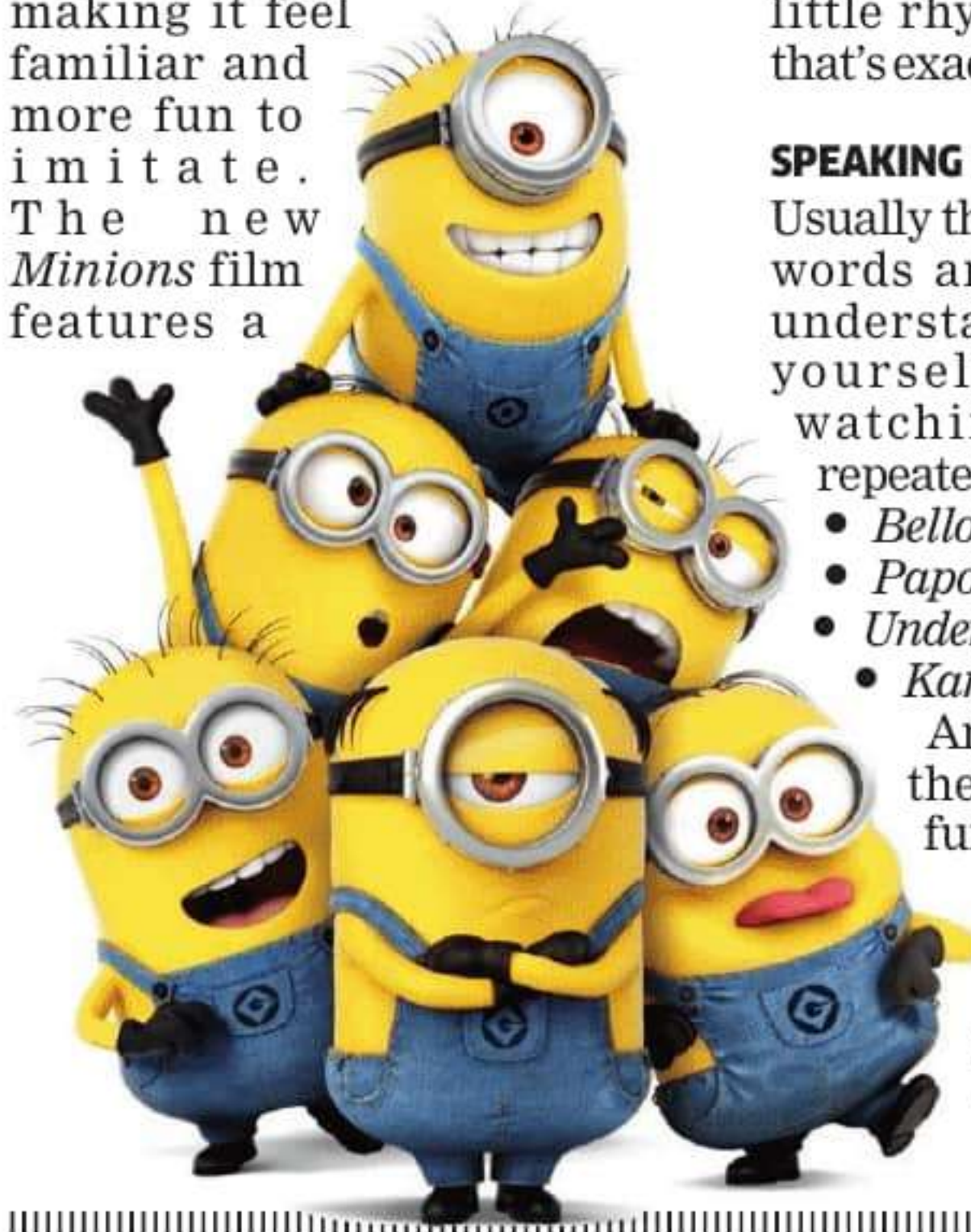
It was clear when *Despicable Me* premiered in 2010 that the real stars were the little yellow sidekicks. The minions have appeared in seven films — four *Despicable Me* movies and, making the jump from sidekicks to stars, and three *Minions* movies.

After more than 15 years, the mischievous helpers have managed to stay as popular as ever. Part of that staying power may come down to the way they communicate.

Minions speak Minionese. But what exactly is that?

Well, it's complete gibberish. The fake language borrows recognisable words from several languages, including Italian, Spanish, German, Japanese and even Indonesian. It was created by director Pierre Coffin, who also voices the little guys.

By blending elements of multiple languages, people from around the world can recognise pieces of Minionese, making it feel familiar and more fun to imitate. The new *Minions* film features a



15-minute scene spoken entirely in Minionese, an acknowledgment of how this made-up language has captured audiences.

WORDPLAY

Made-up languages have existed in storytelling for centuries. Jessie Peterson, creator of languages for TV, films and video games, said one of the most notable examples comes from *The Lord of the Rings* by JRR Tolkien, though humans have been inventing languages much longer.

"As long as humans have had language, they've had fun playing with it, and the earliest documented created language systems go back to the 11th century," Peterson said.

Constructed languages have continued to thrive in fictional worlds, including Klingon in *Star Trek*, Na'vi in *Avatar* and Chakobsa in *Dune*, a language Peterson helped create with her husband, David, for the films.

Peterson emphasised that Minionese differs from those languages because its words have little rhyme or reason — and that's exactly the point.

SPEAKING UP

Usually the minions' actions and words are simple enough to understand, but if you find yourself confused while watching, here are some repeated phrases:

- *Bello* — hello
- *Papoi* — toy
- *Underwear* — I swear
- *Kampai* — cheers

And if you want to talk in the language more, have fun with it. The minions are bubbly and carefree, why should their language make perfect sense?

— The Washington Post

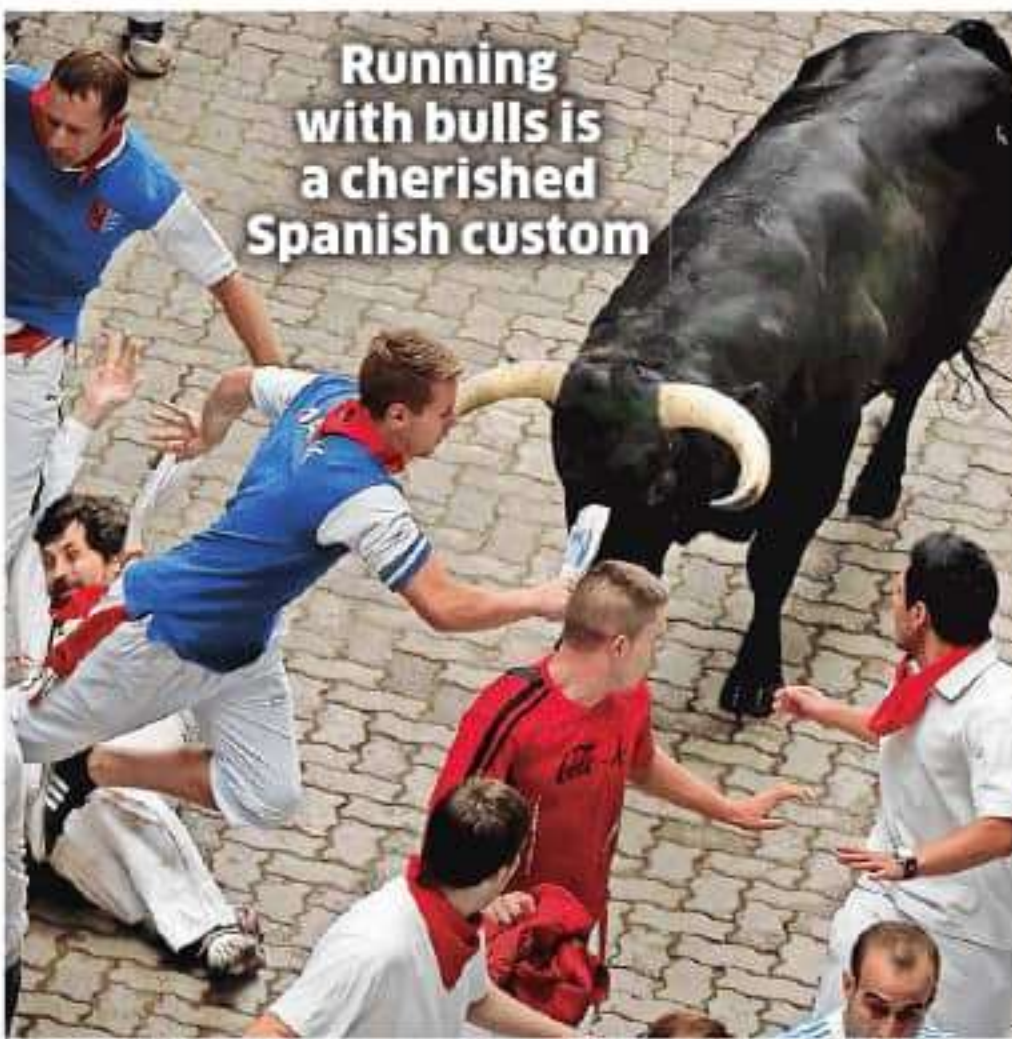
A Masterpiece Turns 100: Hemingway's Bull Run at Pamplona

Bill Hillmann has been gored three times while running with the bulls in Spain, but the still wouldn't miss the San Fermin festival.

This year marks the 100th anniversary of Ernest Hemingway's *The Sun Also Rises*, the book that launched his career and put Pamplona on the map. The novel captivated generations of readers with its Jazz Age tale of American and British bohemians trying to fill some inner void with the distractions of exotic travel, vast quantities of alcohol and the anguishing pursuit of impossible love.

Over the years, *The Sun Also Rises* has become a cornerstone of the American literary canon, up there with F Scott Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby*. It also popularised the term 'lost generation' to describe the tight-knit group of early 20th-century writers expatriated in Paris.

Hillmann was 19 when Hemingway's vivid depiction of the bull running festival first enthralled him, especially descriptions of average Spaniards risking their lives at the nine-day festival. "I sat there for about six hours, well past midnight, reading the book," Hillmann said, looking down at the bulls ahead of their run through the cobblestoned route. "By the time I was done, I was going to be a writer and I was going to be a bull runner."



NATIONALITY SPLIT

Hillmann is one of many Americans travelling to Spain for the fest. While running with bulls is a cherished local custom among Spanish daredevils, Americans are the leading group of foreigners who run at the San Fermin festival. In 2022, 16% of the bull runners were Americans, the largest percentage among foreigners and four times more than those from neighbouring France.

Hemingway is etched into the landscape of Pamplona. Hotels and bars have busts of him or signs up that he was once there. Outside the bull ring, which also has a statue of the writer, a huge banner hangs in honour of the novel, including this quote: "At noon of Sunday, the 6th of July, the fiesta exploded. There is no other way to describe it."

— AP



A miniature living room by Audrey Gelman



Pottery work miniatures



Dollhouses by Lee Thomas Seawell

PICS: IGMA, LEE THOMAS MINIATURES

With life often feeling big and scary, many people are drawn to the nostalgic nature of miniature worlds, where everything remains in their control

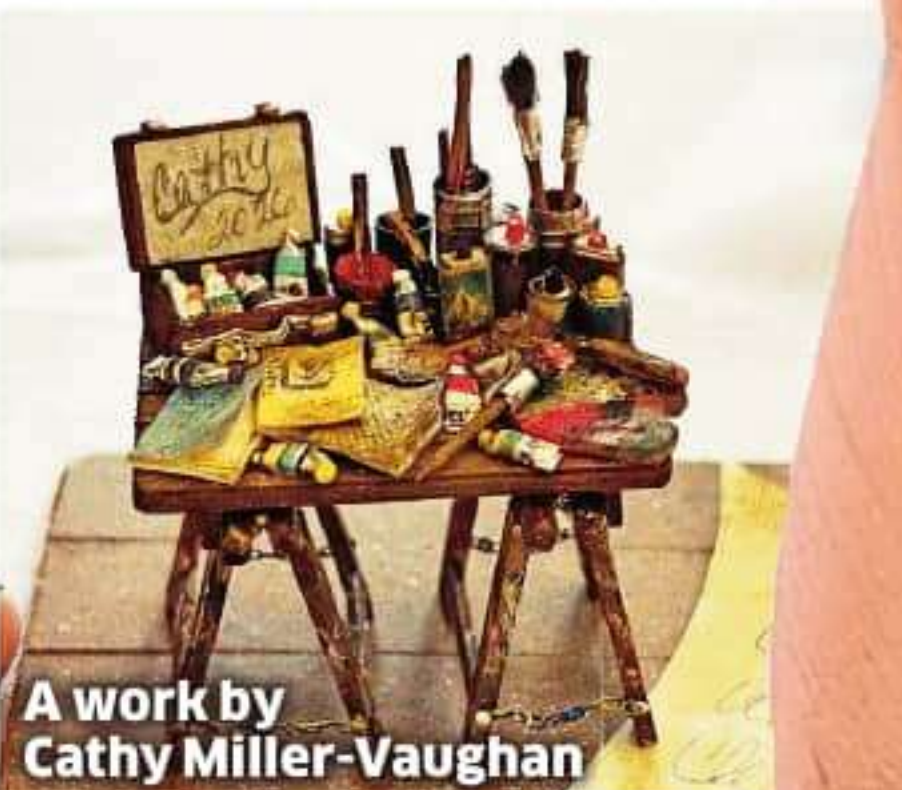
Small Wonder

like a tiny, frozen moment in time. It's satisfying and rewarding to sit back after an hour or two and look and feel proud of what you made from paper and little wood scraps."

Sieg, who lives in California today, recalls attending her first miniatures show and wondering: "What in the world? People actually make this?"



A miniature stained glass window



A work by Cathy Miller-Vaughan

Realising that she wasn't alone was eye-opening. "I dug in deep and thought, 'We can make a living off this if we want to.' It gave me the backbone to start figuring it out myself."

Sieg today has a business creating content and also running a shop on Etsy. She has nearly 5,44,000 followers on TikTok and 1,87,000 on Instagram.

Most of Sieg's creations are traditional, but a few — such as tiny sex toys and drug paraphernalia — are more

whimsical. "A lot of my miniatures are more modern and adult, things you don't think about when you think about dollhouses," Sieg says. "People think, 'Oh, I don't have to do this old-school Victorian dollhouse.' It changed their mindsets."

WHEN SMALLER IS BETTER

Audrey Gelman, 39, began collecting antique miniatures — including esoteric items like a tiny coffin and

an electric chair — during the pandemic. Then, after making a room box (a single miniature room display) for one of her friends, Gelman became obsessed. "There's this feeling of the wonder of childhood when working on miniatures," she says.

Gelman, who owns an inn in New York, researched dollhouse creators for the interiors of her inn and came across Seawell. He built her a 1:12 scale model of its interior and exterior, which is today the lobby's focal point.

Gelman also asked Seawell to teach two workshops at the inn. The first, in March, included a history lesson on miniatures, after which participants crafted bucolic spring scenes. "Everyone was sitting there smiling," Gelman says, adding that the 20 attendees included an actress, a flight attendant and a psychoanalyst. "It was an intense weekend — the [Iran] war had just started," Gelman says. "People said working on these crafts [had] ... a feeling of 'Okay, we have total control over this little world we are making as the world is spinning out

Pandemic shutdowns and social media posts by miniatures hobbyists have helped bring about a resurgence. Today, there are more than three million posts on Instagram tagged #dollhouse

PIC: AI GENERATED

'Whitney was one of the wittiest people I've ever met'

Queen of Funk Chaka Khan on old friends, new projects and living on a farm

Queen of Funk Chaka Khan can add Godmother of electropop to her epithets, thanks to a new album collaboration with Sia.

The 10-track record, *Chakzilla*, also includes collaborations with Snoop Dogg and Lenny Kravitz.

Working with Sia (50), a fiercely private performer, whose standout tracks include 'Chandelier' and 'Titanium' with David Guetta, has clearly been a blast for Chaka (73).

She says of her: "That's my baby. She's my goddaughter. She really is. She is a genius. I couldn't have written those lyrics better myself."



Chaka Khan and Whitney Houston during a performance in April 1999

PIC: GETTY IMAGES

Another star Chaka is effusive with her praise for is the late, great Whitney Houston. And 14 years since her death, the pain still lingers.

Chaka says: "She was an honest, amazing singer and they only come once in a blue moon... I miss [Whitney] because of her singing, but more for her sense of humour: She kept me on the floor. Rolling. She was one of the funniest, wittiest people I've ever met."

STARTING OFF

Chaka became world famous while performing lead vocals with the band Rufus from 1972 to 1983, leading to iconic hits such as 'Ain't Nobody' and 'Tell Me Something Good', written with Stevie Wonder. Born Yvette Marie Stevens, Chaka grew up in a bohemian, cash-strapped family on Chicago's South

Side. Given the African name Chaka at 13 by a Yoruba priest, she was introduced to jazz by her grandmother and formed her first band, The Crystalettes, at just 11 with her sister Yvonne (later Taka Boom). After leaving school to sing in Chicago clubs, she joined Rufus at 18.

Asked if she ever felt intimidated, being so young, she says: "No, never. I knew why I was there. I knew why I was on this earth."

RISE TO FAME

Married three times, Chaka is now happily single. She has two children, Indira Milini Khan (52), and Damien Holland (47), and says she's grateful she found fame before social media. "There's something to be said for mystique," she says.

"There is none of that any more, or very little."

But Chaka's rise to fame has, at times, incurred immense personal cost. She has been open about her past addictions to heroin and painkillers. The 2016 accidental

fentanyl overdose of her close friend Prince prompted her and Yvonne to enter rehab.

Her son Damien was acquitted this year over the 2024 shooting of aspiring rapper Christopher Bailey.

Chaka bought an estate in the Chattahoochee Hills in Georgia in 2023. She says: "I live in the country. I've got a lake. I've got land, I've got chickens, I've got horses, I've got family. I've found my peace and that's everything."

— Daily Mirror

Food Tasting History and the Promise of Prevention of Poisoning

FOOD FABLES



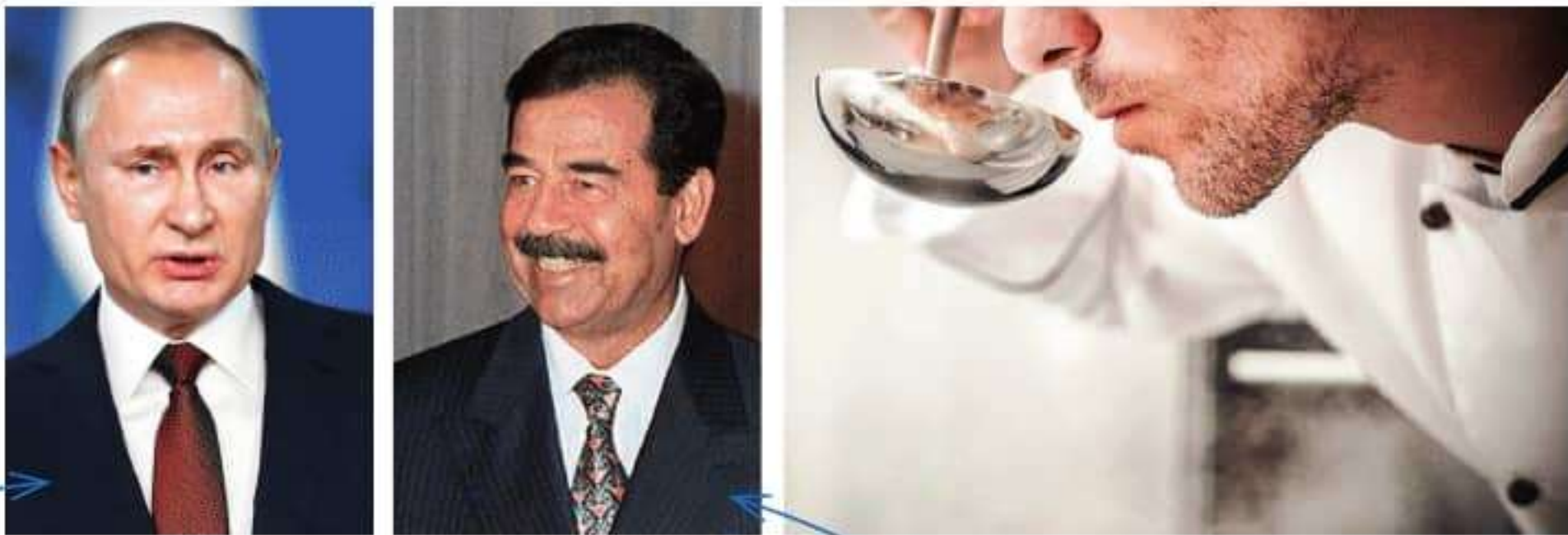
VIKRAM DOCTOR

When members of the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) recently protested at having to do food tasting for VIPs, it seemed an anachronism. Food tasting took place in medieval courts, when poison was a constant threat. Is it still needed today?

Security protocols require samples of food prepared for VIPs to be preserved to test in case they fall ill.

FDA officials were also asked to taste food in advance. Quite apart from the physical challenge, many officials were being diverted from regular duties. Medical officers recently managed to escape similar duties by arguing that their regular work was more important. FDA officials are now asking the same.

Perhaps it's proof that we are not (yet) so paranoid that pre-tasting food seems excessive. In a place like Russia, from imperial tsars to Soviet presidents, food tasters are a fixture. In 2008, *The Times of India* reported about how an order for 3,200 mice by the Kremlin could be a way to find non-human tasters for President Vladimir Putin. In 2012, a 95-year-old German woman named Margaret Wölk revealed how, as a young girl, she was forced to be a taster for Hitler. She recalled his "very good food like white asparagus, wonderful fruits,



Rather than depend on a single taster, royal courts tended to evolve complex systems to ensure safety of food. Tasting would begin in the kitchens and move to the dining room, where they would be placed on a side table for more tasting

peppers, cauliflowers". But there was always the fear of poisoning, as she waited a couple of hours before the food was deemed safe.

Authoritarian rulers often choose trusted aides as tasters. Wakil Ahmed Mutawakil was first a student of Mullah Omar, the

Taliban leader, then his driver and food-taster and finally spokesman and foreign minister. But intimacy brings risks. Kamel Hana Gegeo, the son of one of Saddam Hussein's chefs, became his food-taster, bodyguard and, even introduced Hussein to his second wife. But

PICS: AP, GETTY IMAGES

this brought the enmity of Hussein's violent son Uday, who bludgeoned Gegeo to death during an official dinner.

Rather than depend on a single taster, royal courts tended to evolve complex systems for ensuring the safety of food. Tasting would begin in the kitchens, which were usually far from dining rooms, so the food would be covered, with guards, to the dining table, where they would be placed on a side table for more tasting. We still call these side tables *credenzas*, from the Italian for 'credence' tests performed on them. One result of all this was that the food was often cold and any attempt at an appetising display was messed up.

Rich food lovers wanted an alternative, and they hoped *bezoars* were the answer. These arcane materials have received modern attention after being mentioned in

the *Harry Potter* books. They are solid masses that develop in the stomach of goats (and other ungulates) around hair and other indigestible substances that don't get excreted. Perhaps because goats have famously formidable digestive systems, *bezoars* were seen as antidotes to most poisons. Their rarity helped, since unlike with pearls, no one has ever found a way to induce their making. *Bezoars* traded at huge prices for the rich to dunk in their drinks, or scrape off shreds to eat.

Which is where a Jesuit in Goa, named Gaspar António, spotted an opportunity. Around the mid-17th century, he devised a way to make artificial *bezoars* called 'Goa stones' out of various exotic materials. In

an article published in 2020 in *Vesalius*, the journal of the history of medicine, the Portuguese scholar Maria do Sameiro Barroso examines recipes for Goa stones preserved in the Jesuit Library in Rome. The ingredients included

ivory, pearls, coral, fossil shark teeth, rhino and deer horns, camphor and various minerals.

At the Jesuits' College of St Paul in Old Goa (only a gate still survives), all these were ground together, allowed to age and then

formed into balls. For a while, these were a major export item from Goa. Buyers made elaborate gold containers for them and they are now displayed in museums, proof of the profits that lay in a promise of prevention of poisoning.





FORMULA ONE

Norris Denies Hamilton Record Hungary Pole

Budapest: McLaren's Formula One world champion Lando Norris denied Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton a first pole position since 2023 with a last-lap blast in Hungarian Grand Prix qualifying on Saturday. It was the first time this season, at the 11th round, that leaders Mercedes had not secured pole position for a Grand Prix. Hamilton joined Norris on the provisional front row, subject to a stewards' enquiry, after the seven-time world champion missed out by a mere 0.012 of a second on what would have been his first pole since Hungary three years ago. **Reuters**

LINEUP

1. Lando Norris (McLaren) 1:17.207

2. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) 1:17.219

3. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari) 1:17.445

4. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) 1:17.479

5. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) 1:17.684

6. Max Verstappen (Red Bull) 1:17.725

7. George Russell (Mercedes) 1:17.760

8. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull) 1:18.856

9. Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls) 1:18.281

10. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi) 1:18.686

West Asia Unrest Could Take F1 Season Finale to Imola

Budapest: Ferrari's home circuit of Imola has emerged as a likely host for Formula One's season-ending race if grands prix in Qatar and Abu Dhabi cannot go ahead due to conflict in West Asia, with Malaysia set to return in October. Qatar is due to host the penultimate round of the championship on November 29, with Abu Dhabi following on December 6. The current plan is for both to proceed but informed sources indicated Imola's Autodromo Enzo e Dino Ferrari, in the birthplace of F1 chief executive Stefano Domenicali, had become a frontrunner to step in should circumstances rule out West Asia. If confirmed, Imola would be the first season-ending race in Europe since Spain's Jerez circuit hosted the finale in 1997. Malaysia is set to slot in on October 4 as a replacement for the Bahrain Grand Prix, which was called off in April along with Saudi Arabia's race in Jeddah. **Reuters**

SQUASH
Anahat First Indian to Reach World Junior Final Since 2005

Ontario: Anahat Singh has become the first Indian to reach the World Junior Squash Championship final since veteran Joshina Chinappa achieved the feat in 2005. On Friday, the top seeded Delhi girl beat Egyptian 3/4 seed Barb Sameh 11-3 8-11 11-4 11-6 in the semifinals. World No. 20 Anahat, who was a semifinalist last year, is just one step away from becoming India's first World Junior squash champion. "I'm really happy. I played Barb a few months ago at the British Junior Open and it was a close match like this, so I knew I'd have to play really well," Anahat said. "I've played in four World Juniors and lost in the quarters and semis, so reaching the final has made my parents and coaches really happy, but the tournament is not done yet." Anahat will meet Egyptian second seed Ruqayya Salem in the final. **PTI**

Cape Verde World Cup Hero Vozinha Set for Chile Move

Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha, who emerged as one of the World Cup's biggest surprise packages, has reached an agreement to join Chilean side Colo Colo, club president Anibal Mosa said on Friday. The 40-year-old free agent will travel to Chile to undergo a medical before being officially unveiled at the Estadio Monumental. Mosa told reporters ahead of Colo Colo's league match against Deportes Limache. Mosa said Vozinha's World Cup performances showed he deserved the move, while acknowledging the signing also carried marketing appeal for the Chilean side. **Reuters**

Polio and Taunts

Polio had struck him when he was five. "My family says that I got polio when I was 5 years old. I had to sit down and walk... People used to taunt me." The taunts did not stop there. His unusual first name has a painful origin. His family spent everything they had trying to treat him after he contracted polio. "Friends of his father mocked the family, saying, 'Aap ka beta sab jhandu kar diya, sab paisa khatam kar diya (Your son has wasted all your money)'. The nickname stayed. He once tried to change it to Avinash Kumar. But during a visit to a government office, officials called out 'Jhandu Kumar'. Curious, they summoned him inside, asked his name repeatedly and burst into laughter. 'I felt if everyone is having a good laugh at my name... then this name is good only.' From that day, he embraced the

Boxing: Sachin Survives Stern Canadian Test to Reach R16

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Lawn Bowls: India Beat Tonga in Tie-Breaker

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Chad Le Clos Makes CWG History with A Record 19th Medal

Glasgow: South African swimmer Chad Le Clos became the most decorated male athlete in Commonwealth Games history after winning a bronze medal in the men's 4x100-metre freestyle relay. The record 19th medal took Le Clos past shooters Phil Adams of Australia and Mick Gault of England. "I shouldn't be crying at bronze, I should be crying at gold, but honestly this means the world," the 34-year-old Le Clos said on the games website on Friday. Le Clos' Commonwealth haul was up to seven golds, four silvers and eight bronzes. And he may not be finished in the Tollcross pool — he's also entered in the 50- and 100-meter butterfly races. Le Clos made his Commonwealth Games debut in 2010 in New Delhi, where he collected five medals at age 18. These are his fifth Commonwealth Games. In a glittering career, he's also won four Olympic medals — one gold — and 16 world titles, mostly in butterfly. He plans to compete at his fifth Olympics in 2028. **AP**

Kishan, Varma Fifties Help India Seal Series

Harare: Ishan Kishan and Tilak Varma struck half centuries as India beat Zimbabwe by 90 runs on Saturday to win a T20I series. Wicketkeeper Kishan made 81 off 44 balls and unbeaten Varma 60 from 29 deliveries at Harare Sports Club as the tourists took an unassailable 2-0 lead. The final match is scheduled for Sunday. A second victory in three days marked a turnaround for India who arrived in southern Africa after series losses in Ireland and England. Sooryavanshi, the 15-year-old batting prodigy who scored his maiden T20I half century on Thursday in

Why Philadelphia is the Perfect Final Stop for King James

The 76ers offer LeBron one last chance to make NBA history by winning a championship with a fourth franchise

Tim Reynolds

Those NBA schedule-makers who have been stuck in limbo can go ahead and hit overdrive now. LeBron James might have made their work pretty simple. Opening night, go ahead and expect Philadelphia at New York. Christmas Day, go ahead and expect Philadelphia on the schedule. National television games, go ahead and give Philadelphia a ton of those, too. The 76ers got perhaps the biggest bargain in sports history on Friday, when James — the NBA's all-time scoring king — announced he would be finishing his career in Philadelphia. It is mindboggling to consider that LeBron James (at about \$3.9 million) is going to cost the 76ers roughly as much as rookie Labaron Philon (at about \$3.6 million) will this coming season, which simultaneously makes no sense and perfect sense. James, as always, knows exactly what

FROM POLIO TO PODIUM

Jhandu Kumar overcomes disability, poverty and years of hardship to power India to first medal in Glasgow

Aparajita Upadhyay

When Jhandu Kumar's name echoed through the arena after he secured India's first medal of the Commonwealth Games, it carried a weight far greater than the bronze hanging around his neck. "Jhandu" was a name thrust upon him after his parents spent everything they had trying to cure his polio. Today, the name has made India proud.

The 28-year-old para powerlifter from Bihar clinched the men's heavy-weight bronze on Friday with a total of 130.9 points after successful lifts of 181kg and 190kg.

His bold attempt at 196kg, which could have propelled him into contention for a higher medal, ended in disappointment.

"The happiness is overwhelming. I haven't been able to sleep since last night... Even when I lie down, sleep just doesn't come," he told reporters during a SAI interaction.

The failed final lift, however, does not haunt him. "I took the first lift safely. If I had taken the first lift harder, and if I had failed, there would have been a problem for me. The confidence would have been down. My aim was to pass the first lift. After that, the second lift was to get into medal tally. The third lift was for the gold medal."

"I could not get the gold medal. It was a technical fault. I made a mistake in my breathing in haste. When I was going up, I did the lift right. But when I went out, it (barbell) got stuck in the rack." Long before he was calculating medal-winning attempts, the Bihar power lifter was fighting battles far away from the sporting arena.

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From that day, he embraced the

name. "Now in all our documents, it is Jhandu Kumar. So, there is no existence of Avinash Kumar any more." Life remained a struggle. His parents still sell vegetables in their village, while he spent eight or nine months driving an e-rickshaw to finance his diet and supplements.

ROAD TO POWERLIFTING

The road to para powerlifting was equally accidental. Initially a shot putter, Jhandu had never heard of para powerlifting until Bihar coach Kundan Pandey spotted his physique and suggested he try the sport.

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The Courage To Continue

What keeps champions going when there is little left to win? The answer lies in the deeply personal battle between vulnerability and belief

He cut a forlorn figure in a sea of humanity. It has been a week since Lionel Messi stood by himself as red shirts around him exulted in celebration. At 39, Messi knew his quest to re-feel the feeling he had felt four years ago lay shattered. He had been divine all tournament — with left foot and right, servicing his grateful team, and finding the back of the net in the most critical moments. Yet, there he was, standing alone, crestfallen and broken — the most human of gods.

Sport places a unique burden on its most elite practitioners, one that everyday mortals can never quite fathom. As their stellar careers progress, and the accomplishments stack up, the inevitable questions start creeping into the discourse: What more is left to achieve? Why continue punishing the body and mind? How will another title embellish this already glorious career?

Such questions reduce mighty sportspersons to mere bean counters. But they are far more than that. They define themselves not only by giddy success, but also by the private battles they overcome. Barely a week before Messi en-

dured the trauma of watching his World Cup dream melt away after an unusually insipid performance, another modern-day colossus was reminded of his fragility.

Novak Djokovic is also 39. At Wimbledon, while the narrative was about his quest for an unprecedented 25th major title, the Serb was on a journey of self-discovery. Blocking the surround sound out, he willed his body and mind to emerge victorious in a brutal quarterfinal that lasted over five hours. A couple of days later, across him stood a rival that simply eviscerated the mighty Serb. On a court where he had crafted some of the greatest moments of his career, Djokovic was visibly brittle — a step slower, his shoulders drooping as his younger opponent, at the peak of his powers, clinically dismantled any hopes of a miracle. Djokovic was, just as Messi would be in the very near future — human.

"It is kind of that internal battle really of what I've been through for the 20-plus years of my career; what the goals were always, the expectations, and trying to balance it out and really be a little more humble in that sense," he reflected later, in a searing self-assessment. "I feel when I'm healthy; I'm still able to play as a top-five player, still able to compete at the highest level."

It is in these moments of vulnerability that elite athletes reveal what powers their obstinate refusal to walk quietly into the sunset. Only recently, as speculation over his retirement swirled across social media, Rohit Sharma walked onto the hallowed turf at Lord's. The arena was his refuge, away from the clutter and comment, where he was just reacting to a ball hurled his way, doing what had defined his life — bat. The hundred he produced, peppered with some signature stroke-making from his playlist, was much more than yet another statistic.

Much like Djokovic, Rohit reaffirmed to himself that he was "still able to compete at the highest level." That internal battle had been won, and fittingly, he left the decision on whether a 40-year-old should be part of India's quest to win the World Cup in South Africa in a little over a year, in the hands of those entrusted to make it. Rohit had done his part. He had prepared. Competed. Delivered.

Sport, in essence, is an intensely private jostle that plays out in full public glare. The joy of watching the very best practitioners of a craft is not merely in ticking off measurable outcomes. It is in understanding their embrace of vulnerability, and in their refusal to cave in simply because failure could pockmark the grandeur of the feats of their storied careers.

and were always struggling with only opener Bennett (32) and wicketkeeper Tadiwanashe Marumani (24) enjoying some batting success.

Yash Thakur claimed his first T20I wicket by dismissing Bennett. His delivery outside off was lobbed behind the stumps and Kishan made a simple catch.

Left-arm spinner Abhishek Sharma (3-17), another 2026 T20I World Cup winner, was the most successful Indian bowler. **AFP**

BRIEF SCORES
India: 219/5 (Kishan 81 off 44, Tilak 60 off 29) beat Zimbabwe 129/10 in 17.5 overs (Bennett 32 off 19; Abhishek 3/17, Prince 2/10, Yash 2/30) by 90 runs

FACTFILE

LEBRON RAYMONE JAMES
Born Dec 30, 1984 (Age 41)
Birthplace Akron, Ohio, USA
Height 2.06m | Weight 113kg
Amateur St. Vincent-St. Mary High School, Ohio
Turned Pro 2003 NBA Draft first pick

TEAMS	TEAMS
Cleveland Cavaliers	2003-2010
Miami Heat	2010-2014
Cleveland Cavaliers	2014-2018
Los Angeles Lakers	2018-2026
Philadelphia 76ers	2026-2027

NBA Finals Most Valuable Player: 2012, 2013, 2016, 2020
NBA All-Star Game MVP: 2012, 2013, 2016, 2020
NBA MVP: 2009, 2010, 2012, 2013
NBA all-time leading scorer: Surpassed KAREEM ABDUL-JABBAR (38,387) in February 2023, finished 2025-2026 season with 43,440 points. James has scored 51,961 points in regular season and playoffs combined
NBA All-Star 2005-2026 (22 times)
NBA All-Star Game MVP: 2006, 2008, 2018
NBA Rookie of Year: 2004
NBA scoring champion: 2008
NBA assists leader: 2020
Olympic champion: 2008, 2012, 2024
FIBA Olympics MVP: 2024

James' criteria. On paper, if everything went right even before Friday's news, the 76ers were already primed to be a contender. Now, with James, anything less than contention would be utter failure. And while some will say he's ring-chasing, it's hard for that argument to hold up considering that Philadelphia hasn't won a title since 1983.

Regardless, this task for James won't be easy. The Eastern Conference is absolutely loaded. The NBA champion Knicks play 100 miles away from Philly, and that rivalry will somehow get even hotter now. If the 76ers go to New York for opening night, when the Knicks get their first championship rings in 53 years, those crazy prices for games at Madison Square Garden for the NBA Finals might seem like pocket change.

And the East is much more than just the Knicks. Detroit won 60 games last season. Toronto — maybe — will be bringing Kawhi Leonard back. Cleveland will be in the mix. Miami added Giannis Antetokounmpo; the Heat were waiting to see what James would decide and now will look to add

I still want to sacrifice. I still want to compete, to win and to have a chance at the feeling of winning another championship
LEBRON JAMES

more shooting and backcourt help. And if this past season was any indication, even though trading Brown was puzzling to some, it would be foolish to count Boston out of anything.

"This is my last decision," James wrote. "I'm not going for money. I'm not going for family. What am I really playing for at this point?"

There will be growing pains. Miami started 9-8 in James' first season with Chris Bosh and Dwyane Wade. Philadelphia is starting over in many ways; it's not as simple as it sounds to just plug Brown and James into the starting lineup for Paul George and Kelly Oubre Jr. Brown, James, Embiid and Maxey will have to figure it out, and it will take time. There will be losses. Trust the process, as they say in Philadelphia. It will be a process.

But if they figure it out... James could play quarterback and just spread the ball around all day if he wants. He can still fill a stat sheet like almost nobody else. He and Embiid won Olympic gold together. Maxey is just coming into his own. Brown is going to have a chip on his shoulder the size of the Liberty Bell to prove the naysayers from Boston wrong. If this works, it's going to be spectacular. If it doesn't, it'll be a spectacular flame-out. There is no in-between.

So, now the NBA schedule can be finished. It was the question — where will LeBron go? — that the whole league was asking, and with all respect to Allen Iverson's nickname, Philly was The Answer.